



flirting

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FLIRTING

A Hotwife Novel

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

“It’s *so* hot,” Emma complained. Emma’s nature is so sweet that even her complaints are delivered as pleasant sighs.

I watched as she leaned her head back and squinted at the enlarged sun in the hazy sky, while subconsciously wiping away the tiny droplets of moisture that had gathered on her smooth, buttermilk chest.

I was sure that Emma had no intention of looking as sexy as she did, because that never seemed to be Emma’s *intention*. My eyes wandered to a fat drop of sweat rolling slowly along the curve of her right breast. It gathered momentum and dashed into the shadowy valley between her pert mounds.

Sex was on my mind, as usual, because Emma and I didn’t seem to have the time to have sex these days. But now, we were on vacation, and Emma had stripped down to a clingy teal camisole, with no bra between the fabric and her breasts. Her nipples seemed to have melted in the heat, like tiny caramels in the soft brown pools of her aureole, but they were still visible through the fabric, as chewy round bumps at the crests of her tits.

She had also changed into a pair of running shorts somewhere along the journey— a pair I had never seen, made of a flimsy, tent-like material, and barely long enough to reach her upper thigh. To add to her allure, her skin was covered in a sheen of sweet-smelling sweat.

I took another long walk over her body with my eyes. Her legs had definitely developed some lean muscle since she had started working out at the beginning of the year, and she was all-around more fit. She looked great.

A little pang clamored in my chest, brief and cool, as I thought about how Emma had taken to working out right at the beginning of the year, calling it a New Year’s resolution. I had stolen a glance at her My Fitness Pal app, though, and all indications (as gleaned from her goals) were that Emma had taken up working out with the intention of being in shape just in time for this vacation.

I won’t lie. That had me both a little worried, and a little turned on. A rational man might have just assumed that Emma wanted to look good in a

swimsuit at a summer vacation on a lake with old friends who would dutifully compliment how fit she looked.

I'm the sort of irrational man who preferred to have darker thoughts about it than that.

Emma took a long swallow of cold water, and then poured some over her chest and arms.

"Hot," I said, almost involuntarily.

Emma looked at me, and it was hard to read her expression through her large-framed dark glasses, but she looked almost disdainful for a moment. Then she broke into a wide, beautiful smile. "Oh *that*," she said, shaking the water bottle a little to indicate that she understood I was not referring to the weather, but rather, the way she had just poured water all over her skin like a model in a cola ad. "I didn't do that to be *hot*," she said.

Then she paused, grinning impishly.

"I did it to be *cool*."

I smiled for her lame-ish joke, which is really Emma's forte. She is one of those sweet, wide-mouthed brunettes, who are not conventionally beautiful but *are* incredibly hot, and most of her hotness had to do with her over-generous smile.

It was the sort of room-illuminating smile that no one ever forgot, and she had a tendency to stop halfway through a sentence to use it, quivering a little at first as though the smile were something she couldn't hold back. When she laughed at one of my really good, or corny jokes, she did it with full enthusiasm, her big, white teeth flashing. Her mouth, and her low, nasal voice (a "cool girl's voice," as though she had smoked all her life) made her really sexy even though she was a little bit of a ham.

She liked to make puns, deliberately those puns that weren't very good. We had gotten into a kind of a comedy routine about it.

She pulled on her loose hair, which was a thick, light brown, wavy halo that reached just to her shoulders. She fastened it in a pony-tail and took another sip of water. This time she really hammed it up, licked the edge of the water bottle while giving me googly eyes, before sucking on the end of it.

Emma was also one of those women who did not understand that a "joke" like that (it was a joke for her, because she found that sort of overt sexuality to be "completely silly") was still hot to *me*. Completely silly or

not, a woman licking the end of anything even remotely cylindrical in shape is hot.

“Hot,” I repeated. I was starting to get *actually* turned on, and since there was no hope of that getting taken care of any time soon, I sort of wished she’d stop.

Instead, she smiled, holding the end of the water bottle between her teeth, and my cock swelled.

“Okay,” she said, after taking a last swig of water and handing me the bottle. “Let’s hit the road and go straight through so we can get there by... whatever. So we can *get* there.”

The air conditioning in our car, a Toyota Camry, was petering out on us. This was an annoying event in a long chain of events, beginning with our “real car” (my car, the Lexus, a proper symbol of success and adulthood that I had really wanted to take to the lakehouse) being hit by a semi-trailer in the grocery store parking lot.

Emma refused to get a rental because it didn’t appeal to her sensibilities as the resident cheapskate, and then the Camry – her car, just the sort of thing an underpaid, do-gooder nonprofit manager like herself would drive – began, like an old person, to collapse bit by bit, starting with the air conditioning.

It still turned on and made an effort to convince you that the air was cool, and of course, I *wanted* it to be cool, so I went along with the ruse for the first 200 miles of our trip. But then Emma had turned to look at me, and had yelled: “Oh my God! Pull over!”

Because my face had evidently been as bright red as a tomato.

“You want me to drive?” Emma asked, opening the passenger door.

I took the water bottle from her playfully. “I’m not so old I’m going to keel over and die from a little heat,” I said.

Emma shrugged. “I dunno....” she teased. “Heat stroke really affects the elderly.”

Emma was eight years younger than me, making her thirty-two. Jokes about my age were some of her favorite, favorite corny jokes to make.

I opened the driver-side door in response, and dropped into the cabin of the car, which had baked the leather interior.

“Oh my God!” Emma squealed, when she sat down on her seat. She jumped up, and the skimpy-shorts peeled away from her skin and gave me a nice view of the scorched red skin on her bottom.

I settled into the seat and grimaced, because I am a *man*.

The steering wheel was on fire. I gripped it fiercely.

“You want a towel to sit on...? Oh my God,” Emma said, seeing what I was doing. She shook her head. “You are crazy,” she added, spreading a towel over her seat.

“I’m a man!” I declared.

She shook her head, cursed as she touched the seatbelt, and clicked it in. “Crazy,” she insisted quietly, a smile on her lips. Then she shrugged. “Shall we?”

Three hours remained in the drive. I planned to do it in two by driving 150 miles an hour where possible. I had related this plan to Emma as we drank four gallons of iced tea in the restaurant next to the gas station, in order to cool off. She had found my plans for speed amusing enough to give me one of her partially-hesitant smiles. Then she advised me that the Camry couldn’t even do eighty.

Emma leaned back and sighed, waving her hand in front of the air vent. “I think it’s windows-down for the rest of the trip.”

It was fun, driving along with Emma, sweat rolling down her thighs, her hair (when she untied it) blowing in the wind. It was too loud to talk, which I didn’t really mind because it gave me a chance to look at her.

But these really weren’t the circumstances under which I wanted to be arriving at our semi-annual reunion. I had my reasons for that. Normally I wasn’t the kind of guy to get too focused on my stuff as a measure of success (Emma, being the non-profitteer that she was, saw to that). We didn’t live in a high-headroom house, or buy a new car every two years, or vacation in five-star hotels in the Caribbean, which are only things I mention because my buddy Alec *did* all those things.

It used to not matter to me very much. Alec was always the salesman, always the ambitious, alpha-type who was going to have fast cars and hot women in his twenties and then a trophy wife in his mid-thirties and some kind of foundation named after him in his fifties. He was always that guy. It never bothered me that much... until I turned forty.

Well.

And then there had been the last reunion.

I stared into the tall corridors of green that lined the expressway, threatening to grow right over the concrete as we watched. Summer in New

England, a short and torrid affair, a season that was always anticipated with relish and quickly became too much.

Only two more hours to go.

The lakehouse had belonged to our friend Toby's parents, and we'd spent almost every summer there when we were in high school. It had been sold while we were in college, but Alec had surprised us all one year by inviting us to a reunion for a week at the same lakehouse of our youth, which he had purchased just for that reason.

Because, you know: Alec is the kind of guy who can buy a house just because he wants to use it for a trip down memory lane for one week out of the year.

Toby almost never managed to get out here, and I suspected that it was because Alec had taken a sledgehammer to the interior of the lakehouse and fixed it up in really expensive teak and modernist decor. Objectively, it was a lot better than the plaid-and-neon-avocado look Toby's parents had left behind, but I could see how Toby might be bothered by the attack on his sentimentality.

At any rate, it was an annual event that almost always ended up happening every two years instead of every year.

As we rolled down to the driveway through the heavy, overgrown trees of late July, I could see that two cars were already there. One was a sleek, black Jaguar (Alec's) and the other was a truck.

Chris.

"Is Chris... like, bringing anyone, or what?" Emma asked. Her brow was furrowed slightly. She jammed her thumbnail at her teeth.

As though summoned by the sound of his name upon my wife's lips, Chris appeared in the front doorway, arms extended against the frame, muscles and tattoos coiled and tense. He was shirtless, which as I thought about it was pretty much the only way I saw Chris anymore, and his stomach was a veritable poster-ad for fitness.

Except for all the scars that criss-crossed his chest, arms, and abdomen, from the sixty-odd "really stupid" things he'd done. For Chris, this was a category that only included near-death experiences with surgery. He was a base-jumping, squirrel-man, helicopter-piloting, crotch-rocketing crazy person.

You might be thinking I would be concerned that Emma was asking this question – about whether Chris brought anyone – because she was secretly attracted to bad-boy Chris. But Chris was too much for Emma, and I suspected, sincerely, that her interest in his girlfriend was purely related to safety, since the last girlfriend had been thirty seconds from burning the house down in the middle of the night.

Emma's dad was the fire chief, so she didn't take those shenanigans lightly.

"You never know what you're gonna get with him," I said. And it was true. One year he had brought a mild-mannered librarian named Rebecca who was doing a thesis on something unimaginably boring and who had not set anything on fire, smoked, or drank the entire weekend. So go figure.

Hands appeared on Chris's chest. They were dark brown, with slender fingers and black nail polish. They traveled over his abdomen, lightly caressing his six-pack, and then dug into his gut so fiercely the black disappeared.

Chris whirled around and disappeared with the dark-skinned legs and black hair that whirled around with him.

"Oh boy," Emma said under her breath.

I turned to her after I parked the car. I put my hand on her knee. "Hey. I really appreciate you being cool with this," I said.

I didn't even know why I still came to these things. We were all on such different trajectories in our lives. Alec had gotten married and started bringing Luz, his wife, so I had started bringing my wife, too. Chris brought whatever girl he had at the time, and she was always a different girl. It wasn't like there were a lot of close friendships going on here among the ladies, and the guys had drifted apart.

Still, it was a free vacation, as Emma liked to point out.

Emma, I remind you, is the penny-pincher around here.

Emma smiled.

"Well," she said, exhaling sharply. "It *is* a free vacation."

She stepped out of the car, but not before untying her hair and running her fingers through it.

"You guys are here!"

Luz, Alec's model-thin but bountifully-endowed wife trotted down the steps, smiling and looking like she had just walked out of a Martha

Stewart magazine. For all I knew, that was where she actually lived while Alec was “away on business.” Her makeup was flawless, her roots invisible, her tan a precisely calibrated shade of toasted almond. Her dark eyes, the color of a good stout beer, were framed by long black lashes, and her lips were pretty and red. Emma had aptly, and perhaps jealously, dubbed her the “Mexican Barbie Doll.” Everything about her was flawless and looked too perfect to be real.

“Hey, Luz,” Emma said.

Alec appeared in the doorway. He also looked like he came out of a magazine, and a little odd in a shirt and shorts, which were casual but somehow gave off an expensive look about them. I doubted that Alec owned anything, even a slice of bread, worth less than \$50.

Luz kissed Emma on the cheek and peeked around her, her pretty features making a cartoonish impression of “confused.” “But where is your other car?” she said, as though someone had died. “And why are you so hot?”

There was a moment here, one of those moments like so many others, as I’ll explain later, where everyone just paused, and looked uncomfortable, and shifted a little from side to side. Emma, I knew, was trying her best not to make a corny joke out of the double-entendre. I know what I was doing: trying not to be embarrassed about the car. Alec – and maybe I remember this wrong – was looking at my wife, and in no way attempting to hide that he was checking out her newly-toned physique.

It lasted only a moment, with Luz standing there blinking and genuinely desiring the answer to her question. Emma’s mouth started to open.

“Ricccckkkkkay!”

And we were all saved by Chris, who launched himself out of the doorway (literally), jumping over the entire porch and landing on his feet as though he had merely strolled there. He swung his big arm in my direction and I did what I usually did: put mine up in the air and hoped he was planning to high-five me and then do some kind of secret handshake that, as of the telling of this story, only Chris knows how to do.

He slapped my hand good and hard, and I braced sufficiently to keep from falling over. We squeezed hands and then he tried to do something else and the top-secret handshake fell apart.

No matter to Chris, or to anyone else, because the stunning owner of the black fingernails had sort of floated into the doorway and leaned on it.

She was the kind of girl that you immediately assumed was part native-American, maybe because she had very straight black hair almost to her elbows. Her body was long and her skin was darker than Luz's. She wasn't the kind of girl who would make you turn around in the street, but she was the kind of girl you would never forget. You could tell that just by the way she stood in the doorway, reminding everyone of an amused cat.

And then she just kind of slinked down the porch and folded herself up on the steps, her limbs almost too long for her to cross up. She was wearing a pair of cutoffs, and they rode up the crease of her thigh when she sat down. The white shirt that hung loosely off one shoulder was a thin material that slipped over her breasts and occasionally clung to her dark aureole, and the chocolate-colored nipples in the center of it.

All this, and everyone just watched her do it, because it was like watching someone dance the tango. Not explicitly filthy, but not sexually neutral at all. She folded her long fingers up beneath her chin and gave me a closed-mouthed smile.

"This is Thalia," Chris said, sweeping a hand to gesture toward her.

Thalia's left eye almost closed into a wink, and the air seemed to sizzle dangerously around her. Her legs fell open a little and the cutoffs just kept riding up, further and further, with no underwear in sight.

"Hi," Emma said, waving at her by opening her hand and closing it. Emma treated Chris's girlfriends like they were a cross between a zoo animal and a small child, which honestly wasn't too far off the mark most of the time. Though my impression of Thalia fell almost entirely in the former category; she seemed 100% jaguar.

"I am going to bring you a cold drink," Luz declared, completely immune to the effect that Thalia's appearance had on the group.

Luz was the sort of gloriously unsubtle, peroxide-and-silicone beauty queen who did not get upset about women like Thalia. Luz knew that the kind of moneyed men she wanted to like her preferred her own platinum hair, perfect measurements, and spa-treated beauty to that of women like Thalia. "What do you want?"

Emma put her hands on her hips, fingers against her bottom, and waved her elbows a little. "A, uh... what are you having?" she asked me, stealing a glance in my direction.

“We’re all thirty-six sheets to the wind, little lady!” Chris shouted, confirming that this was likely true, at least for himself. “Bring her a shot and a beer!” he called back to Luz, who had clicked her way back into the house in her spotless white heels.

Thalia turned and watched her retreat with the same strange, amused expression on her face, and then turned to my wife and gave her a smile. “Chris says you like to go skinny dipping,” she said. Her accent was thicker than Luz’s, but betrayed a similar provenance.

Emma’s mouth fell open a little.

I had wondered how long it was going to take for someone to bring up the antics of the previous year, and now I had my answer.

I looked over at Emma. I felt a little sorry for her, because Emma was not exactly a cut-loose and skinny dip kind of gal. She had been very, very drunk, and very, very sorry the next day.

And then there was that other matter.

Emma’s eyes went quickly to me, but then just as quickly to Alec, and then down at her feet as her cheeks probably got hot. Luckily for her, she was already beet-red from the car ride.

I cleared my throat. “Is the air on in there?” I asked. “Because we’re baking.” I looked at Alec, though I couldn’t say what made me do this. “Lost the air,” I explained.

Alec’s skin was folded above his brow as he glared at the Camry. “Why are you driving that heap?”

Emma stuck her foot out and folded her arms. She gave a shake of her hair. “It’s *my* car, jackass,” she said. “And it’s because the other one’s totaled.”

Alec smirked and brought a beer to his lips. “Your fault?”

A lot was going on here, in the form of Thalia still looking at Emma as though she expected her to answer the question about skinny-dipping, and Chris doing an impromptu handstand on the edge of the porch (this was the sort of thing no one paid much attention to), and Alec burning a hole right through the fucking space-time continuum looking at my wife.

Or perhaps I was imagining that last bit.

Emma smirked back. “No. It was parked.”

Alec raised his eyebrows. “No rental insurance?”

Emma rolled her eyes and sighed, stepping backward to open the door of the Camry and remove her small suitcase. Emma and Alec had a long

history of social-justice-versus-Gordon-Gekko-capitalism fights, and I took it that she viewed this conversation as an extension of that history and wasn't drunk enough to continue the battle.

I looked at Thalia, the magical creature on the steps. She seemed to have been warned about all of this, though one had to wonder where Chris found the time between handstands and base-jumping to describe it to her. Chris also wasn't renowned for his ability to observe other people's drama. He'd probably completely forgotten our last reunion, because in his world it was supremely boring.

Also, Thalia looked like a real wildcat in bed, and so I couldn't imagine them spending much time chatting.

Thalia rose suddenly, and like she was made of liquid. She turned and headed into the house. Chris, who had been doing a kind of handstand/push-up, dropped to the ground, jumped immediately onto the porch, and followed her.

"Oh!" I heard Luz say, "You are all coming back in!"

And then a clink of glass bottles as she turned around.

I slid my arm around Emma to walk her toward the door. Alec moved behind us as we walked, and I heard his car door open. I didn't turn around, and neither did Emma, so there's no proving it, but I could feel his eyes on Emma's ass until we entered the house.

Emma went to our usual bedroom to unpack her things right away, putting them neatly into drawers and hanging in the closets, because that's the kind of girl Emma is.

Imagine a slightly less quirky, much more attractive Leslie Knopes. She took my suitcase with her.

Thalia disappeared, and from the (non)reaction of everyone else, I took it to be the sort of thing Thalia did often.

I slammed my beer. Alec came inside.

Luz swayed her curvaceous hips back to the kitchen.

I waited until the room was clear.

"So," I said to Chris. "Thalia."

Chris crossed his legs in front of him as he leaned on the couch and pried a cap from a beer that I would have sworn was not a twist off. "She's a hot one," he said.

"How long have you been dating her?" I asked. Not that I cared.

Chris scratched his head and brought the beer to his lips. "That is... a good question."

Luz brought me another beer. She was way into playing hostess at a civilized party and she was unflappable. She held her hand out for Chris's bottle cap, gave him a small and expensive-looking cocktail napkin, and kissed him on the cheek. "Don't put that onto my nice new table over there without a serviette," she purred. "Where is Thalia? I'm making her a *Michelada*."

"This girl," Chris said, referring to Thalia, "does not eat anything unless it has hot sauce in it. She eats like forty jalapeños a day. One time she grabbed my -"

"Hey," Emma said, appearing soundlessly next to our cluster.

She looked at Chris. "Well, don't stop talking on my account," she said.

Emma was now wearing her own cutoffs, which were nowhere near as racy as Thalia's, but she had stuck to the teal tank top, and she looked... well, more provocative than usual. I wasn't sure how I felt about it, and my insides twisted accordingly – one direction for turned on, proud of my wife and the way Chris's eyes traveled all over her body, and an opposite direction for jealous possession.

Chris looked her up and down. "Lookin' tight, Mrs. D," he said. "Workin' out?"

Emma smiled graciously. Chris was a real bastard, and he was irritating as fuck, but no one could get annoyed with him. He was just one of those guys.

"Thanks, Chris," she said. "I am, actually."

And then another awkward moment, as Emma looked to the side, where Alec was standing, caught herself, and looked quickly back at me.

"Hey Emma," Luz called. She pronounced Emma's name "Aim-ah." "You want to try this Mexican drink, it's called a *Michelada*?"

If there was one thing "Aima" probably didn't want to do, it was try a Mexican drink. If Thalia was the kind of girl who would not eat anything without hot sauce on it, Emma was her polar opposite.

"Is it hot?" Emma called out.

"Hot drink?" Luz repeated listlessly. I could never tell if she was actually a bimbo or just putting on an act. "No, it's cold."

“She means is it *picante*,” Alec said dryly. He looked at Emma. “Don’t have it,” he said. “You won’t like it.”

This was another too-intimate moment between Alec and Emma. They looked at each other, and then Emma sighed and rubbed her arms. “I’m too cold now,” she said. “I’m going to sit on the porch. Chris, what’s your girlfriend’s name?”

Chris told her, and Emma went into the kitchen to get another drink from Luz.

“If she has one of those,” Chris said, leaning toward me, his face earnest and sincere, “you should *not* have a blowjob tonight.”

He slapped his fingers together by waving them in the air, and bit his lower lip to indicate that the experience would be unpleasant.

I tipped the second beer back and gulped it.

I felt like Alec was staring at either me or my wife, and it was unnerving me.

I knew I was probably reading all kinds of stuff into this whole thing.

Every time I got around to thinking that it was all in my head though, I remembered our last reunion. A mix of dread and arousal always sifted through me when I did.

My chest went cold with the strange mixture again, and Luz reappeared with more booze, which I eagerly drank up.

CHAPTER 2

A few hours later, everyone had caved and begun drinking the Mexican ladies' *Micheladas*, even Emma, who had been cajoled into it by... you guessed it... Alec.

We moved things down to the dock on the water. The lakehouse was built onto a steep rocky slope on a private lake, so there was no beach, not even a rocky one, just a long dock into the water and a tethered dock about a hundred meters out where the ladies liked to sunbathe.

The usual conversation, I'll call it the "first-day-dick-measuring" conversation, ensued. Alec was, unsurprisingly, still killing it at the obscure and slightly-illegal sounding financial shit he did, which somehow involved futures trading.

Emma, as usual, got a little annoyed listening to him.

Thalia seemed to pick up on this, and, lighting a cigarette, struck up a friendly conversation with Emma by blowing two smoke rings and asking, sexily: "So Emma, what do you do?"

"I work at a nonprofit organization that helps develop and deliver potable drinking water and hygiene technology to developing countries," Emma said.

Thalia blew smoke from between her lips in a steady, fast stream and rolled her eyes over to Alec. She gave an unreadable grin to the whole situation, and then ashed into the water. "You must really hit things with Alec, then," she said dryly.

The missing "off" of her misused idiom hung in the air like a heavy weight, made even more awkward by the fact that what she had *meant* to say and what she had said were the very sources of the tension between Alec and Emma that I was pretty sure everyone perceived. Emma *wanted* to "hit things" with Alec, if you asked me.

The comment made everyone slightly uncomfortable, except for Luz, who was on the floating dock and probably didn't hear. Well, and Thalia, who seemed like the sort of person who didn't give a shit if she made people uncomfortable or not.

Thalia hopped to her feet, like a ninja, cigarette still between her lips. "Well," she declared. "It's time for some shots."

And she walked up the stairs, leaving Chris, my wife, Alec, and I to share slightly uncomfortable glances.

Emma looked down at her feet. “Well. As long as we don’t do anything we didn’t do *last* time,” she said quietly.

Chris was doing some sort of acrobatic, parkour thing at the end of the dock now, leaving only the three of us.

Alec laughed, which I was grateful for. I put my hand on Emma’s knee.

Chris, whose motives I was also never sure of, broke the ensuing silence. He was upside-down in an odd and difficult looking handstand. “You guys ever been to Rayas Magos?”

He did a handstand push-up.

No one answered.

“They. Have. Cliff. Divers,” Chris huffed. “And one of them died while we were there last time.”

No one knew what to say to that, and it took Chris a long time to pant it out between his crazy pushups.

Thalia appeared at just the right moment, with a stack of shot glasses in one hand and a bottle of tequila in the other.

“Oh,” said Emma, holding the back of her hand to her lips. “I can’t.” She even looked like she was turning a little green.

Thalia leaned over, with her very nicely-shaped ass right in Alec’s face, and set the shot glasses on a small glass-topped table with machine-gun quickness. “Oh, this is not shitty tequila, this is agave one hundred percent. It’s good, you’ll like it.”

Thalia looked over the tequila bottle at Emma. “Trust me,” she said.

She opened the bottle by using her teeth to tug out the cork, which was a delightful sight, I have to say – especially when it popped out. Then she poured carelessly, like a bartender who has watered everything down, except when she lifted the glasses to hand them out, there was not a drop spilled.

Emma took one, because Thalia was not the kind of girl you said “no” to, and Emma was not the kind of girl who had an easy time saying “no” in the first place.

Thalia gave a quick toast in rapid-fire Spanish, and then shot her tequila back in a single gulp.

Emma sniffed it, and seemed less unhappy than expected.

I sipped mine, because I was forty years old, which is too old to be doing tequila shots with a bunch of guys.

Alec shot his. Smoothly. Like everything else he did.

Thalia had the bottle ready to pour another shot. She looked at me fiercely. "Hey, you. What is this?"

I shook my head. "I'm okay."

Thalia's eyes rested on me, and I could have sworn I felt like a lead blanket had been draped over my shoulders. "Don't be a *puto*."

"I'm not, I just -"

"Baby, Rick here has definitely put in his time, he used to drink us all under the table."

Thalia put her hand on her hip.

"I do not believe it," Thalia declared, after looking me up and down.

The tequila by now was burning nicely on its way down my esophagus. It was a good, pure agave tequila with no grain alcohol, smooth and not the sort of thing you slammed.

Which is the sort of thing I should have said. Instead, with this very tall, pretty goddess staring down at me with her hand on her hip, challenging my manhood, I did what any guy would do: I slammed my tequila.

Emma rotated the shot glass in her fingers and stared at me.

"Órale!" Thalia said, and poured me another. "Now you," she said to Emma.

Now, the Emma I knew would have shook her head very quickly, her pretty waves rolling over her shoulders, and then given everyone one of her million-watt smiles and explained bravely that she had gotten very, very sick on tequila when she was in high school, and that would have been the end of it.

But there was something mesmerizing about Thalia. There was the "boys club" atmosphere of the lakehouse.

And then there was Alec, staring at my wife. "C'mon, Emma," he said, and his voice was a wild mix of tenderness and cajoling. "Drink up."

Emma looked at me, then at Alec, and Thalia took advantage of the stolen glances to reach forward, touch the bottom of the shot glass with her fingertips, and slowly tip it toward Emma's mouth.

And just like that, we were on our way.

“So,” Thalia said. “You are the guy who can drink us under the table, huh?”

After anywhere from three shots (Emma) to eight (Chris), we were good and loaded, and the party was in full swing, in the sense that everyone had broken off into chat groups and there were no more awkward silences. Which, I suppose, is what the booze is for.

Thalia was sitting with her legs folded and crossed in front of her, playing with her toes and looking at me. I’d lost track of both her shots and mine, but she’d had quite a few and she should have looked a lot worse than she did.

Alec piped up from where he had sprawled in a deck chair. “Rick here is just worried that something... racy... will happen again.”

Thalia’s eyes lit up and she stretched out to reach for a lime from a bowl of them Luz had brought down on one of her many trips to the kitchen. Thalia poured hot sauce on the lime and then sucked on the fruit with a long slurp. My imagination quickly compiled, played, and dissolved a scene for me: Thalia’s lime-and-chili soaked lips traveling the length of my cock. A phantom burn traveled the length of my semi-hard shaft.

“And what’s this terrible thing that happened last time,” Thalia said, pausing to suck on her thumb with a glint in her eyes. “Come on. I want to know.”

Emma, who was talking to Luz at this point, prickled, but kept her face rigidly on Luz.

“There’s no need,” I said, trying to sound casual.

Thalia poured more tequila (we were on a second bottle) in a shot glass and handed it to me. She drew her own glass along her lips and met my eyes. “Oh,” she said, in her sultry, low voice. “But I want to know.”

I had a full-on erection, and it would be a lie if I said that Thalia had nothing to do with that, if in a very dangerous and frightening way. Not that I would ever sleep with a girl like Thalia, especially not now that I was married to my lovely Emma. But when a girl that hot says things with tequila glistening on her lips in a voice like that, with her legs dangling out of a pair of cutoffs that quite clearly are not covering any underwear, well... things happen.

But more than Thalia, the reference to our last reunion, which should have made me angry or embarrassed, or... anything but turned on... was partially the cause of it.

Thalia stared me down, and I shook my head, and she called me “puto” under her breath.

“I’ll tell you what, *maricon*,” she said. “We will have a contest, and if I win it, you will tell me what happened, okay?”

Chris chuckled as Thalia stood up. This was a bad sign, Chris chuckling, because Chris only laughed at things that *he* found interesting or funny, and those were usually things that no sane or rational person found funny at all.

One thing I didn’t think of was that I didn’t have to enter into a challenge just because a long-legged sexy Mexican girl told me I did, but like most guys, that logical connector had sizzled with the commando jean shorts and half a shot of tequila. Long ago.

“And what do I get if you lose?” I said. It was then that I heard my own voice, and realized I was drunk. It was also dawning on me that there wasn’t too much of a story to tell, so this was a pointless contest I was getting myself into.

Emma was turned toward us now, and so was Luz. Thalia’s long arm dropped to her side and she found the shot glass with her fingertips, and seemed to levitate it to her mouth.

She shrugged. “I will stop asking this question,” she said, and slammed her shot.

It was a bad deal, and I knew it, but I was too drunk and Thalia was too mesmerizing.

“Okay,” I said. “What’s the contest?”

Thalia swung her torso, leaving her hips motionless. “Anything you want,” she said. “Drinking contest, whatever.”

Alec was amused. Emma looked worried. Luz had her bedroom eyes on, which meant she had been drinking and her comprehension of English had completely disappeared.

Thalia asked her something in Spanish, and Luz smiled and murmured something back.

“Okay, if you are going to be a *puto* about this drinking,” Thalia said to me, “pick something else.”

The insides of my eyelids felt like liquid. I was too drunk for any of this.

I considered arm wrestling, because Thalia was small. But she had that caged animal look about her, like she might have been top dog at a

women's prison or something, and being beaten by a girl at arm wrestling would really be embarrassing.

I looked around, too drunk to figure out that I had been backed into a corner and didn't need to be there at all, too drunk to think straight enough to find a good challenge, and too much of a man to turn the whole thing down. I looked at the water, the dock, the small rocky "island" about 200 meters out, my wife, Alec, and the defiant Thalia, before I came up with this brainchild:

"Let's swim to the island and back," I said, pointing at Thalia.

"Honey," Emma protested immediately. "That's a terrible idea, you're too drunk. It's night."

"It's a deal," Thalia was already saying.

And just like that, she was lifting her shirt over her head, walking toward the end of the dock. As I had suspected, she had no bra or suit on under her shirt, and as she shimmied out of her jean shorts, I saw that she was also not wearing any underwear.

"Oh my God," Emma said, as Thalia sat down next to her and dipped her toes in the water. "You aren't actually going to... you guys, this is dangerous, you're too drunk."

Alec waved a hand lazily at the end of the dock. "Meh," he said, "it's only deep for about fifty meters and the rest of the time you can stand if you want."

Emma pursed her lips.

I stared at Thalia's bottom on the deck, the dark cut between her small buttocks, the lines of tanned flesh. She was weaving her long black hair into a braid. She looked over her shoulder and back at me. "You coming?" she asked. "Or do you... *como se dice?* Forfeit?"

I had completely forgotten the bet, or what it was for.

But I was *not* going to *forfeit* to a girl.

I stood up.

Chris laughed again and put his fist to his mouth. "Oh, boy," he said.

I took my shirt off.

"Rick," Emma said, looking up at me.

"I've swum to that island a billion times," I said drunkenly. "Way drunker than this."

"It's true," Alec said. His eyes were on Thalia as she finished her braid and stood up next to me. I had my shorts on and I was not taking them

off for anything.

Thalia's naked body was dark and lean, and her two small breasts were upturned with long, chocolate-colored nipples. With her hair pulled back her face took on a regal quality. Her dark eyes moved up and down my body. "Ready?" she asked me.

Decidedly, I was not. I was having trouble standing up straight, and my shorts were going to drag, and as I looked at Thalia's upturned chin and athletic body, I realized that she was probably going to kick my ass.

"Yes," I said confidently.

"Oh, God," Emma groaned. She started to look around, and I knew it was for a flotation device.

"Take your marks," Chris said, but he was laughing so hard you could hardly understand him.

Thalia reached behind her head and tied her long braid into a knot.

I stared at her tits.

"Get set..."

She lifted a foot and brushed something off her sole.

"Go!"

She was in the water like a knife, and that was the last time I saw her.

I sort of belly-flopped – not bad, but enough to be painful. The water was cold, and as it chewed into me, I thought I would have an advantage. I *was* a good swimmer, and I *had* swum to the island a thousand times drunk, and Thalia was a woman with no body fat and that would work to her disadvantage.

It was only halfway across that I remembered that body fat worked to the advantage of women, and even a waify thing like Thalia had more than a man. I reached the island, which I realized when I scraped my knee on a rock. I lifted my head from the water and turned back to see where Thalia was. It was dark by then, the lights at the end of our dock seemed wildly distant, and a cool breeze was picking up out there.

I finally saw her arms in the water. In and out with the precision of a machine. Well, I thought, maybe I could claim that I'd thought the race was *to* the island, and declare victory, and swim back slowly with her.

I wiped my face and squinted at where I had last seen her.

And then I realized, as an even cooler chill dripped down my body like a slushy ooze: Thalia was already swimming back.

CHAPTER 3

When I got back to the deck, Thalia had evidently dried herself off with a towel that she had placed on the deck and stretched out on, without bothering to get dressed. Emma looked irritated when I hauled myself out of the water. She handed me a towel with a grimace.

Thalia was stretched on the towel on the deck, the curves of her naked body caught in the candlelight and distant porch light, slices of yellow-white against the burnt almond of her lean limbs and supple breasts. My eyes strayed to the center of her legs, where her pussy was completely bare.

She was looking right at me, relaxed and amused, the expression on her face indicative that she had known all along she would win.

Chris shook his head. “Thalia grew up in a fishing village, man,” he said, cracking up. “She's been swimming with a knife since she was like two.”

Naturally.

The knife part sent a half-terrifying, half-delicious shiver up my spine.

“This story is going to be boring isn't it?” Thalia yawned, lighting a cigarette that seemed to have materialized out of thin air. “But let's hear it anyway.”

I sighed.

I insisted on having a few more shots, and Emma disappeared upstairs saying that she was going to make snacks. Or something like that. So I began.

And I certainly didn't tell this story in the literary, descriptive way I'm about to tell it here, because no one talks like that. And I probably omitted a large chunk of the story, like the parts about me sneaking around.

But this is what happened “last time.”

We all got really, really drunk on the third night of the trip. A huge thunderstorm rolled in and the lights went out, and we couldn't be outside, so we lit candles inside, played card games, got shitfaced, and had a great time.

At some point, Luz went to bed. Emma made her take a flashlight instead of a candle, because like I said, Emma is a real nut about fires. She

had tried to wrap the evening up.

“Okay,” she yawned. “I’m tired. Let’s pack it in.”

“Emma, don’t be a loser,” Chris had said playfully.

“I’m not a loser,” Emma had complained. “I’m just old.”

“Go to bed, then,” Chris’s girlfriend, a wild redhead who was maybe twenty at the time, said.

Alec tapped his beer glass. “Fire Marshall Emma won’t go to bed unless we put out all the candles. Will you, Emma?”

Emma smirked at him and cut the deck of cards, which we weren’t playing with anymore.

“Fine,” Alec said, pulling himself from the lounging position he was in and leaning on his knees. “Tell you what. Play one last game with us, and I’ll go to bed and blow out all the candles.”

Emma shot him a look and let the cards fall from her hand into the deck.

“Uh-huh,” she said. “And let me guess. This one last game is strip poker?”

No fooling Emma.

Anyhow, this kind of conversation was not happening for the first time. One of Alec’s favorite activities, as long as Emma had been coming, was to ask her to play strip poker or to skinny dip or do any other myriad of things naked. It had begun as playful teasing, but over the years it seemed to take on a harder, more realistic edge.

And me?

Well, Alec pissed me off, for sure. But less predictably, I found myself rooting for Alec to win sometimes. For him to convince Emma to do something like play strip poker or do body shots. I sometimes thought about these things in the shower, while I jerked off onto the tile: Alec’s lips covering the deep oval belly-button on Emma’s stomach to suck something from inside of it and sending an electric ripple through her body, right to her pussy. Emma peeling her underwear away, only to have them land on the floor with a heaviness that betrayed how turned on she was that Alec was watching her undress. Emma treading water in the lake with Alec, her fingers brushing over his chest... or maybe his cock.

Alec just smiled in response to Emma. “Otherwise you’ll have to stay up *all night*,” he teased.

This was a real predicament for Emma, who I could see was very drunk and tired. But there was no way in hell she was going to bed with candles burning.

She lifted the cards and let them drop back onto the deck a few times, her lips pressing together to hide her annoyance.

But there was always something else beneath Emma's expressions when Alec challenged her like this. Or maybe I should say, when Alec told her what to do.

"Oh God," she said. "Fine. But one game, and then when I win, you go to bed, candles out, no questions asked."

"Done," Alec said, with a wicked grin.

I had my mouth open to protest (I think), but said nothing. Emma looked at me. "What?" she said, shrugging. "Get me another drink."

Emma, it should be said, was so far from being a card shark it was ludicrous. Not only would she not win any game of poker, she would probably not even have been able to say what hand she needed *to* win.

So what did I do?

I got everyone some more drinks.

"Okay," Alec said, dealing out five cards with an unnerving expertise. "The game is five card draw, aces high, ante is an item of clothing, raises are the same. You win the pot, you get to put your clothes back on. We play until someone is naked."

He lifted his eyes to Emma, who blushed. "Unless you want to keep playing after that."

I was sitting on the floor next to Emma. "You don't have to play this silly game," I whispered in her ear. "I'll stay up and watch the candles. Promise."

Emma made a big deal of shrugging. She was uncomfortable, and the thing about Emma is that if you add alcohol to her discomfort, she gets this crazy idea that she has to confront whatever is bothering her. "I might not lose," she said cheerfully. "It's mostly just luck, right?"

"Hey," Alec scolded me, as I peered over to look at Emma's cards. "No helping. Everyone is his own man here."

"Emma doesn't even know the rules of poker," I said.

Alec lifted an eyebrow at Emma. And this might have been the point in the evening where there was a weird shift between them. "Interesting,"

he said.

Emma had surprised me by laughing. Her laugh had been very girly, very silly, and she had even covered her mouth, like she was some Japanese schoolgirl in a cliched movie. "Not really," she said.

Alec had tapped his cards into a neat pile on the glass with two short barks. "Damn," he said. "That's a bold move, Ems."

I moved my eyes from Alec, who was smiling, to Emma, who was drunk, and my head spun as I tried to take in the "why" of why I was bothered.

It was the nickname, and Alec using it, and the sudden turn from the usual static between them to a more genial tone. I only figured that out later, when I reflected on what would take place during the rest of the evening, but at the time it really bothered me. "Ems" - as if they had something between them, a secret or a desire.

I don't have a good recollection of the first few hands of the game. Everyone was losing but Alec. Emma just kept rolling along for a few raises before giving up, so she lost about five articles of clothing right off the bat. She was well-clothed, though, for a game like that: she had on socks and shoes, which I knew she had put on when we lost power and the candles came out, because she didn't want to stub her toe running out of a flaming building.

Soon enough, though, her socks and shoes were gone, and Alec was watching her across the table as she moved her eyes nervously from her hand to the pile of clothes on the table. When she met Alec's intense gaze I could see her eyes wiggle and she seemed to be all aflutter.

"Emma," Alec said, his voice smooth as silk. "You've got to decide."

He was talking about poker, of course, I insisted to myself. But I couldn't help get a peculiar thrill out of the double meaning I chose to infer: *decide if you want to play dangerous strip games with me all night.*

Emma made a noise. "I think I have to... fold..." she said, obviously very flustered.

Chris's girlfriend, the redhead, had been impatient for Emma to get a move on, because she had lost almost all of her clothing and she was in a hurry to take off more. Chris was fondling her big, heavy, pear-shaped tits over the see-through bra she was wearing. Her hands went immediately to the straps of her lingerie.

Alec reached out and grasped Emma's cards before she could set them down. "You'll have to take off something for the next ante anyway," Alec told her, burning through her with his gaze.

Hell, even *I* got a little turned on by the way he was looking at her.

Emma's mouth fell open, and she looked uncertainly around. "But I... I don't have a good hand, really, just..."

Her eyes fell on the giggling, fleshy girlfriend of Chris, who was holding her unhooked bra to her chest with one hand, and her mountains of red hair up on her head with the other. Chris and she were using the pause in play to make out. Chris had his tongue running along the back of her neck.

Emma seemed to calculate something. "Okay," she said bravely, and set her cards face down. "I'm in. I, uh..." she looked at me for the right word.

"Raise," I said, a little dumbfounded.

"Raise," she repeated, like I had taught her a phrase of Swahili. Then she gingerly peeled off her shirt.

Alec raised his eyebrows, impressed, as she set the small shirt in the pile and tried to return her hands to a natural position at her elbows, and look "cool." She shrugged a little and fidgeted. Her breasts were bursting from a small white cotton bra. A breeze traveled through the window, her flesh grew deliciously bumpy along her arms and her nipples perked up visibly beneath the fabric.

Chris's girlfriend threw her bra off with glee and her tits bounced free, tipped by wide, swollen aureole that had been bitten recently. "I'm in too," she laughed.

Chris was down to his shorts, which were likely the last thing he had. He folded, and I knew from his devilish grin it was just to keep the game going, because he had a good hand, which I'd seen while he was munching on his girlfriend's neck.

I raised, losing my shirt, and Alec, who had won every hand and was still clothed, stood up and shimmied out of his shorts. His eyes were still on Emma.

He slipped his shirt over his head, revealing his taut physique. The shirt dropped onto the table. "Raise," he said.

Emma blanched and looked at me, because she wasn't sure what to do next.

“Keep going or fold,” I said quietly.

She bit her lip. I had no idea what she had in her hand, but I knew it was probably not going to win her clothes back. If that was even how this game worked – at that point, I was a little fuzzy on the rules and everyone else seemed to be, too.

Emma took another sip of her gin and tonic, and then gulped one more for good measure. Everyone's eyes were on her as she stood up, pulled her own shorts down to reveal her white cotton panties, and shrugged.

“Uh... meet your raise?” she said.

“Atta girl!” Alec said, and Emma looked at him and smiled shyly.

It was at this point that I could clearly read the signs: Emma was pleased at being cajoled by him, pleased at doing something that made him say, “atta girl.” Fingers of jealousy crept down my spine and into my balls.

Chris's girlfriend stood up, smiling, and gave us a slow, lingering striptease as she peeled her black panties away from her body and let them fall to the floor.

“Carpet matches the drapes,” Chris said.

“And I am.. out of clothes, so I guess, what? I call?”

Chris shrugged as she sat on his lap. “Sure,” he said, looking at me. I didn't have much left to put in, so I was happy about the detour from the rules. I flipped my cards over before anyone could tell me not to.

Emma, of course, had nothing. Chris's girlfriend won, and she giggled as she put on her shirt and shorts, neglecting her panties and bra and chewing on Chris's lip, her tongue playfully darting out to tease his lips before she bit gently into them and pulled them back with her teeth.

Emma, down to her panties and bra, clearly didn't know what to do.

Alec collected the cards and dealt her another hand.

“Oh,” Emma said. “I thought... the game was over...because...” She waved her hand loosely in the direction of Chris's girlfriend.

I understood then that Emma had calculated that the redhead would lose her clothes, and the game would end.

Alec stared at her, holding her captive with his gaze while he dealt.

“But Sally here has her clothes back,” he said.

For the record, this was not Chris's girlfriend's name – not even close- but she was so drunk and slobbering on Chris that she didn't notice or protest.

“So the game goes on,” Alec said to my stunned wife.

Emma looked hesitant, but she reached for her cards.

Alec tiskied. "Gotta ante up," he warned her, his eyes on her bra, practically spelling out for her his desire to see her breasts freed from the schoolgirlish cotton bra.

Emma's wide smile quivered in disbelief. I was so sure she was going to quit that I think I was already starting to stand up.

Instead, she twisted her arms to reach behind her back. She was smiling shyly and with disbelief on her face, almost as though she could not believe what she was doing herself. I stared with what was probably a similar expression as the straps of her bra strained and then sprung away from her skin, loose.

This caught Chris's attention, and his eyes went wide.

I stared.

Alec stared.

Emma, dear sweet little Emma, looked right at Alec as the fabric covering the swells of her breasts loosened. She drew her hand to the center of her bra in front to tug it gently away. The white cotton slipped over her skin in what seemed like the slowest motion possible, before falling into her lap and freeing her breasts completely.

Alec didn't avert his eyes: he stared right at her chest. His lips pressed together in appreciation, and Emma blushed slightly and drew her eyes in a line along the table before she lifted them, briefly, toward me.

"Sally" waved at her bra still on the table. "I'm in," she said to everyone. Then to Chris: "What? No point putting it on just to take it off again."

Chris laughed and stepped up on the couch. "Whoo!" he shouted, and took off his shorts. His thick, stubby cock was erect, no doubt because of whatever Sally was doing to him (and maybe because this was the first time he had a chance to look at my wife's bare breasts). As per usual, he didn't give a shit. He waved his cock around a little.

I sighed, and took off my watch.

"Pussy," Alec said in my direction, but he didn't press me to do anything else.

He stood up and lost his boxers as well, revealing his enormous cock, half-erect, and his toned thighs. He remained where he was, and Emma cast a quick glance up at him before making a face, averting her eyes, and generally freaking out.

“I, uh...” she broke into her wide grin, a reserve for uncomfortable situations. “I have no idea what to do,” she said. “Isn't the... game over *now*?”

“I still have a watch,” Alec said.

Emma stole a glance back at him, and it was so obvious that she wanted to linger on his cock, measure him up, that I got another electrifying chill sent through my balls. “Uh, okay... so...?”

She looked at her cards.

“I think I need to quit,” she said, and I was surprised that she laughed and tossed her cards down. “I don't even know what I have.”

Chris laughed. “You gotta call anyway. Wait, I have to call. Unless there's something else I can bet... whadya think, baby, can you loan me something?” Chris had turned his attention back to “Sally,” who took the hat he was wearing – which none of us had noticed up until now because he wore a cap with such consistency that it seemed like what he grew for hair.

“I'm out,” Sally said, and then added throatily: “But my panties are in.”

We were all very drunk, so it took a while for Emma to realize that this transaction had, somehow, confusingly, put her back into the hot seat. She didn't know what to do, and truthfully neither did I, because the rules of poker and common sense seemed to have been abandoned long ago. Chris and his girlfriend didn't care about anything except taking their clothes off, and Alec and Emma seemed to have forgotten I was even there. It was now just a mission for Alec to cajole my wife into undressing completely.

“So....?” Emma said.

And then another knife of pain plunged into my chest as she looked to Alec for guidance.

“You give up?” he taunted her. “Or are you all in?”

It's pretty hard to explain what it was about the way he said this, almost like a command more than a question.

The effect on my wife was hypnotic. Emma, so out of her element, rose like a zombie to standing.

If there had been a way to bet on what happened next, I would have bet the farm that Emma was going to cover her breasts, make a lighthearted joke, and say she needed to go to bed.

I was so sure of it, in fact, that I let my attention wander slightly to Chris and his girl, because Chris's fingers were rolling Sally's pebbled

nipples between them and she had started to mewl.

When I looked back to Emma, she was inching her panties from her body.

"I guess I'm in," she said, as though the matter were completely out of her hands.

She stripped down to nothing, her skin glowing in the candlelight, covered only by her trim, dark landing strip. She pressed her thighs together tightly – almost more invitingly, in some strange way, than if she had spread them open.

"That's it," Alec said.

Very sexually, almost as though everyone in the room had disappeared but those two, and he was a john ordering around a high-paid hooker. *That's it*, I could almost hear him saying, *ride that cock*.

But by far the most perplexing – and arousing - thing was the way Emma reacted to it: like a trained horse or a faithful dog, she fell right in line and then onto her knees, tucking her feet under her, almost submissively looking to Alec for instructions.

And most surprising of all, I just *sat there* watching, my cock getting harder.

"It's you, buddy," Chris said finally. A long pause had ensued, and Chris had stopped making out with his girlfriend to stare at Emma as well.

"Oh," I said vacantly.

I gave it some thought – as much as I could, because my head was filled with a plasma of dirty thoughts. The only thing I could think of to say was: "Fold."

Alec took off his watch. There was no longer anyone there who knew what had been raised, or by whom, or how many times, or what happened when everyone ran out of clothes, so when he called, no one put up a stink.

"Hmm," Alec said, looking at Emma's cards. "What were you thinking, Mrs. Orr?"

I glanced at Emma's cards just before they were swept away; they were terrible, but who knew if that was deliberate or just Emma's lack of poker knowledge?

Who cared?

"I get my clothes back," Chris said, disappointment in his voice.

Emma's lips quivered the way they did right before she gave away one of her generous smiles, and her eyes moved around the room, from

Alec to me to the direction of Chris and his girlfriend, who were giggling and sorting out his clothes but making almost no effort to get them on.

“That means... game's over, right?” Emma asked. She started to reach for her panties and bra. “So... candles out, and I'm...”

Alec had swiped the clothes remaining on the table away, his eyes on Emma. “Oh, don't tell me you want to go to bed after all that?” Alec said.

Another long pause.

I knew it was probably my duty to say something: Emma had complied with the game and now she deserved to go to bed, and Alec was being a jerk.

It was already on the tip of my tongue.

Alec had a challenging look on his face, which was nothing new.

What *was* new was that Emma had her hands in midair, hovering over the table. She could have gotten her clothes from Alec easily. That's what Emma ordinarily would have done.

The pause was just long enough to give Chris's girlfriend a moment to roll toward Emma, moan sexually from the back of her throat, and complain: “Oh, man, it's so *hot* in here with no air.”

It was.

Chris hopped up from where he was sprawled on the couch. He still didn't have his clothes on. “Let's go for a dip,” he said, and the girlfriend, whatever her name actually was, was up before the idea was out of his mouth.

A dip sounded nice, because it was about 97 degrees in there and 100% humidity. The candles were actually adding too much heat to the situation, and everyone was covered, I noticed just then, in a wet sheen of sweat.

I waited for Emma to look at me. I don't know why... because that's what she would have ordinarily done?

But she didn't. She did one of her trembling, timid-to-enormous smiles, and looked at Alec. Her eyes fell to her bra and panties.

“You lost the game,” he taunted, without taking his eyes from her face. “And you cheated, wearing shoes. I think the least you can do for being so naughty is have a little fun.”

Emma's eyes flashed, but not with her usual anger.

“Uh...” I said. Just to remind everyone I was still in the room.

Alec stood up. “Jesus, it's too dark to see anything anyway.”

He took the candle on the table, leaving us swamped in darkness as he moved swiftly to the door. There was only one small candle, Chris and his girlfriend having taken the other.

“Well,” I started to say, because in truth I wanted to talk Emma *into* going for a midnight swim, naked. I could almost feel her nipples beneath my palm, feel the chill of the water, the warmth of her thighs against me. It would be fun.

But when I lifted the candle, I saw that Emma had already started toward the kitchen. Following the light from Alec's candle.

Naked.

Chris was no stranger to danger, so he had snagged some booze on his way to the dock. Everyone made their way down there shakily: the candles made it harder to see, in many ways. The lights shook in the darkness as we stumbled down the steps, the ladies laughing, the loud, jagged whispers of illicit happenings ricocheting among us.

The thunderstorm that had killed the lights seemed to be long gone, and the air outside was refreshingly cool. I slipped on a stone step and sat down to get my head together, and realized that it was cool enough now – the sky was even cleared of clouds – to just sit outside to cool down.

There was a perverse side of me, too, I knew even at the time, that sort of wanted Emma to continue down to the water without me. I wanted to see if she would get in, naked, with Alec instead of me. How long it would take her to notice I wasn't there.

If she'd care.

I set the candle next to me and blocked the glow with my hand. I could see them better this way: the fast-moving, hand-standing, cartwheeling black figure that must have been Chris.

The voluptuous body that was his girlfriend.

The chiseled rock wall of Alec's body.

And the smaller frame of my wife.

In the dark they moved apart, back together, joining into one shadowy figure with four heads and then breaking apart. All the way to the water.

I heard them splash in. I heard Emma's voice say, “Oh, wow, that's col-”

And then a splash

“You jerk.”

Emma again. But the tone was not the same tone she used for Alec ordinarily. Not the, “you jerk,” as I would have envisioned it. No. This was a quietly playful, “you jerk,” with a little come-hither to it, a little playfulness. The kind of “you jerk,” an eighth grade girl gives you with a fake arm punch right before she lets you feel her up.

The thin veil of clouds in the sky moved away to let a fullish moon light up a path on the lake, illuminating the two couples in the water. Chris and “Sally,” entwined and probably having sex, murmuring and moving to the left, toward a small dark inlet with a willow tree hanging over it that we had all used countless times to hide away with a girl.

And then Alec and my wife, who still had made no notice of the fact that I was not at the lake yet. Nor did they seem to care.

They were maybe two feet from each other, their limbs moving as though they were treading water, though they didn't have to where they were. They were talking, their voices low, and from where I was it seemed that they were moving a tiny bit closer with each passing moment.

A quick breeze blew out my candle.

No one noticed.

Alec and Emma seemed to be only a foot apart now. What *were* they talking about, those two, from such opposite spectrums of.. well, anything you could measure?

Time dragged on, though it must not have gone on all that long. I pictured Alec brushing his hands over Emma's thighs underwater. There where it was black, where no one could see... why wouldn't he?

And what would Emma do, if Alec's thick fingers moved over her inner thigh beneath the black water?

I was entertaining myself with these thoughts when Emma's voice got louder. “Hey, where *is* Rick?”

A pause.

“Rick? Honey?”

I cleared my throat. “Shit,” I said. “I stubbed my.. foot... and my candle is out.”

“Where *are* you?” Emma answered.

My plan, which wasn't even really a plan so much as some kind of montage/set-up that blossomed in my head, a set-up that made no sense from any practical perspective but which I nonetheless wanted, sort of mushroomed in my skull and I found myself saying:

“I'm gonna go back and look for a...”

I sort of mumbled away the end of the sentence.

I heard Emma say, “What?”

But that was all. Alec's low rumble followed, and then a pause, and the figures moved closer (or at least, I thought they did), and I stood up to see if they would see me.

But they didn't. They couldn't, I realized. It was dark and bushy all around: a man like me blended in to the bushes, and as long as I didn't move quickly, they would never know if I just inched further and further down the steps, to a small path that cut off through the wooded area and served as a shortcut to the patch of sand we nicknamed “the beach” and the small pool where Chris had taken his girlfriend.

But the beach was closer to where my wife and Alec were still wading, closer and closer, their voices low and their hands and legs invisible under the glassy surface.

I moved slowly down, toward the path. Through the bushes, I moved quickly, because they couldn't see me and I knew Chris just didn't care.

At the bottom of the path, at the start of the small patch of sand called “the beach,” I was able to tuck up behind a patch of newly sprouted maple and peer into the water.

Now that I'd been outside for a while, my eyes were well-adjusted and it was really quite bright with the light of the moon.

I couldn't hear what they were saying, though. Their voices had dropped. Only occasional patches made their way through. Murmur, murmur, murmur... “No, never?” (Alec)... murmur murmur murmur, Emma's glitteriest laugh, murmur murmur, murmur, “ssssshhh! I can't -” (Emma) murmur murmur.

The water was splashing lightly around them, Emma's voice was crackling and tinkling, playful and flirtatious.

At least, what I *heard*.

They seemed, no matter how hard I tried to reconcile it as something else, to be two people flirting heavily with each other. In the dark water. Naked.

Emma's murmurs had been sending a steady drip of arousal right to my cock, but when they suddenly went silent, and the water continued to splash lightly, the burning arousal turned to a fire. My limbs went cold, my stomach dropped through my body to my feet.

I strained to see them.

They were still apart from each other, though not by much. A foot, maybe? Looking right at each other. Silent. Still moving beneath the water, with the light waves lapping their faces. They seemed to have sunken deeper, their chins just grazing the surface.

How long did this go on? I can't remember. For me, it was an eternity, as I imagined all the things that could be happening beneath the surface of the water: Emma's hands finding the length of Alec's cock, the cock she had wanted to feel, secretly, for so long. Or Alec's hands "accidentally" brushing over Emma's navel, her hip, her inner thigh, the soft curls she had trimmed into a landing strip. Then, oops!... the folds of her pussy, where a different, warmer wetness eagerly awaited him...

I imagined oh so many things as I crouched there, until I could feel my limbs going to sleep. How long was I going to sit there, watching them, waiting for my wife to step over, or be lured, over some line in our marriage that she could never take back?

And why – I wondered this only peripherally – why was I turned on by the idea? Despite the pain of the thought, I could feel that a good part of me wanted her to do it.

But the tension crumbled suddenly. Emma said something, and then Alec murmured something back, and I heard her splashing before I made out that she was moving toward the deck. "Rick? You okay up there?"

I was suddenly aware of what a predicament I was in, because I had no reason to be off in the bushes. The moon, which until now had been my ally, seemed to shine even more brightly on the sun-bleached wood of the steps and deck: they would see that I wasn't there, and they would see me come out of the bushes.

"Where *is* he?" I heard Emma say.

Alec was moving through the water like a shark, getting closer to Emma, saying something about whether or not it really mattered.

"He might need help," I heard Emma say.

I had an idea, and backtracked quickly up the path to cut out of the forested area toward the steps. I did it loudly, which was my intention, but I couldn't have been quiet even if I wanted to because my feet were shrieking in pain as the circulation returned to them. "Here," I said. "I'm here... I went to take a piss."

I was on the steps by the time I said this, so I had a clear view of my wife, her legs floating out behind her, her face turned up toward me, the look of bemusement on her face. And of Alec, who was inches from her legs, his hands moving beneath them in the water, and his expression. Which was more of a smirk, like he knew I was talking out of my ass.

“You grab any more beer, buddy?” he said finally.

“Oh my God,” Emma said. “That is the last thing anyone needs.” Then, to me: “You coming in?”

She turned to float on her back, pushing away from the edge of the dock with her feet. Her body stretched out, silver in the moonlight, glimpses of her aureole, her landing strip, her navel, shimmering under the water. I wondered again if Alec had touched her, what had happened in those moments of silence.

I sat on the dock and dropped my feet in. The water was actually pretty warm, which in this part of the world still meant cold as fuck. Emma was drifting away, and she seemed to be deliberately putting distance between herself and Alec, ignoring him like he wasn't even there.

I sank into the water and stifled my reaction when it lapped at my balls. I spread out my arms and began to swim toward Emma as the cold encircled me all around.

I heard Alec behind us, making the water splash lightly as he pushed himself up onto the dock. I followed Emma out – this lake, as I mentioned before, wasn't very deep. We could still stand.

Emma floated on her back, letting her head float in the water as well. “Wow,” she said. “You really can see the stars here.”

“I'm not looking at the stars,” I said, reaching for her ankle to pull her closer to me. I put my feet on the bottom of the lake. I was so drunk and so turned on by Emma that I didn't care or notice much that it was weedy, which ordinarily I don't care for at all.

“So,” I said, as her body floated slowly toward me, the length of her thigh, then her glistening bush, then her belly button, floating under my nose. “What did you and Alec get up to out here, all alone and naked?”

My hands drifted down her inner thigh, and she was floating with some momentum, so her pussy was going to slowly dock into my fingers if I just left my hand there and she kept floating.

Instead – and instead of answering my question – she abruptly let her legs fall to the weedy bottom, and stood up. “Oh my god, this is so dan-”

she started to say, as though it had only just occurred to her that we were swimming drunk, which is another big no-no for Emma.

She interrupted herself to shriek, though. The weeds had touched her feet.

“Oh God,” she said. “Oh God, oh my god, I hate seaweed, oh, ah! I have to get out of here.”

She splashed and thrashed, and water sprayed me in the face as she motored away as quickly as she could toward the dock, making adorable squeaks and complaints about the weeds.

When she got to the dock, Alec was standing at the edge with a towel. Emma pushed the water from her face and looked up at him. “Oh,” she said. “Uh...”

And then she got out of the water, and stood up, naked. Alec wrapped her in the towel, which Emma at first let him do before it must have occurred to her that it was inappropriate. “It's so weedy out there,” she said. “It freaked me out.”

She squirmed away with the towel, holding it up with two hands, and pushed her wet hair back. Alec was smiling at her, and they paused for a moment too long, looking at each other.

“I'm going to get some more drinks,” Emma called out loudly. “Who wants one?”

She was scurrying up the steps, muttering something about her clothes, before anyone answered.

I don't know if she heard Chris and Sally, who both sounded breathless, about thirty seconds later, call out that they wanted something.

Alec had a towel around his waist now. I moved toward the dock.

“Can't believe you talked Emma into skinny-dipping,” I said.

Alec sat down on the edge of the dock, putting his feet in the water. “I'm glad I did,” he said. “Now I can fill in the gaps in my imagination.”

There were no gaps in my imagination about what this meant. But let's be honest, every guy with a hot wife knows that at least some of his buddies are using her in their spank bank.

The only surprise to me was that, even though I got a little ticked by him saying it out loud, I was also drawn to the idea, the same way I had been while they were in the water together.

“That's my wife man,” I said dutifully, in that tone you use to be honorable without really meaning it much.

“Sure is,” Alec said. His voice was monotone, so I didn't have any idea how to take the comment.

Chris and Sally were splashing over, still giggling and laughing. Still naked.

Alec met my eyes for a good minute or so as the two approached, and then he turned to Chris suddenly and started some kind of horseplay with him. He stood up and dropped the towel, his semi-erect cock long and thick on the dark mat of his pubic hair, before jumping in to try and drown Chris.

Sally, who had managed to have sex with out getting her hair wet, splashed them both and let out a stream of creative and utterly filthy invectives, holding her hair up and wading toward the dock in an effort to keep it dry.

“Fucking idiots,” she muttered. Which I thought was a pretty hilarious thing for someone who just had unprotected sex in a slightly-too-warm lake to say, but I kept my mouth shut.

From there, I expected the evening to quiet down, but Emma, very surprisingly, returned with more drinks. “The lights are *still* out,” she complained. “I don't think I can get to sleep in that heat.”

She had also brought more candles, and slipped into her swimsuit.

She set everything down and wiped some sweat from the back of her neck. “It's a boiler in there,” she said to me.

I watched as she handed out drinks – one to Sally, one to Chris, and one to me. Alec took his time floating over, and Emma seemed reluctant to even meet his eyes.

I watched as she handed him a beer, from a crouch on the dock. I could have sworn that Alec's finger touched hers, moving over her pointer finger in a caress.

I wondered if my wife was capable of any kind of duplicity. If you had asked me before that night, I would have said no. I would have told you that Emma was the type to report any and all impropriety, and usually before it even happened, because she was just too goofy and loyal to do anything else.

But *something* was going on between Emma and Alec, and Emma was pretending it wasn't there.

My chest burned.

We had a few more drinks. Everyone got out of the water. Sally went upstairs to get her suit because she “didn't want splinters in her ass.” She reported that the house was actually hotter than before, which she couldn't understand. We had a long and boring discussion about that, and Sally and Chris got out a joint.

I smoked some, which was a huge mistake, and suddenly I was so stoned and drunk I wasn't sure I was going to be able to make it to bed.

I remember Emma yawning, saying she needed to go to bed. I stood up, putting my hand on her shoulder, and started up the steps. “I have to get to bed,” I remember slurring.

I was so sure that Emma was right behind me that even after all that had happened, I wasn't concerned about heading up the stairs.

I stumbled into bed, and I heard tipsy footsteps coming down the hall. They sounded like Emma: “Sally” would have been loud, attached to Chris at the hip, slurping and maybe even stopping to get a quickie in. Alec's steps were heavy. I lay on the bed, planning to seduce Emma when she came to the room.

The footsteps took her to the bathroom, and the door closed. I heard the water from the shower running, and my eyelids got heavy. I still had the optimism of any man, even though I was so drunk and stoned I couldn't have had sex for a million dollars.

I fell asleep dreaming of what I would do to Emma, sure that she was in the bathroom taking a shower.

When I woke up in the morning, Emma was *not* in bed with me. It took a few moments for me to process this, such was the fog clouding my mind.

When the details of the evening before – and my suspicions – started to come back to me, I sat up with a start, throwing off the covers. I thumped through the house, scanning the scene as I stumbled along. I was the only one awake, it would seem. Doors were closed, lights were on, as they had been before the lights had gone out. Clocks blinked, there were bottles and glasses everywhere like there had been a huge party.

No Emma. No Alec.

I rushed to the doors to the deck, and scanned the outside.

Drifting, drifting, from the blue-gray water to the rocks to the gray of the deck.

To the red blanket, to the two figures beneath it.
Not touching, facing away from each other.
In vain, I searched for the red hair of Chris's girlfriend.
But no, this was a brown-haired woman.

I stumbled back from the window, dizzy, and back to the room where we were staying. I sat on the bed, my mind spinning.

I don't know how much time passed, but I heard the door open and close.

Intentionally quiet footsteps came down the hall.

I rolled onto my side and pulled the covers over me, trying to quiet my breathing and make myself still.

Behind me, the door creaked open. A long pause, while my heart raced and my blood bit at my chest with cold teeth, and then the door clicked as it was closed again.

The bathroom. Running water.

I didn't dare move. My head was spinning. I imagined the duplicitous Emma standing behind me, waiting – for what reason, I couldn't even tell you – for me to turn around so she could catch me (catch *me!*) faking my sleep.

The water turned off. The footsteps crept back. Another door opened, and I heard the low murmur of Luz's voice. Emma was whispering. Two cackles, one Emma's, the other Luz's.

I wondered if Emma was talking to the wife of the man she'd just fucked. If she was burning with shame, or if Emma was such a two-faced monster that she didn't even care.

They had a conversation that was low and unintelligible. The door opened, and Luz's voice tinkled through: "I'll make everybody some breakfast then..."

Emma whispered. "Okay."

The door closed.

Emma lowered herself quietly and gently onto the bed. It was an obviously done in such a way that I wouldn't be disturbed.

I could feel Emma's rapid, guilty breathing next to me. Her heart was racing, and I sensed it was as hard for her to lie still and pretend she was asleep as it was for me.

How long did we lie there? Maybe an hour. An hour while I thought of all the possibilities, over and over again: Emma had passed out on the

deck from drinking too much and Alec had taken advantage of her. They had fucked, and Emma's pussy was wet and sticky with his cum. They hadn't done anything at all.

Would she say something? Would she hide it forever?

And what the hell was wrong with me? As I pictured Alec and Emma on the deck, stark naked on the red blanket, fucking under the moon, his long, thick cock stretching her pussy, pistoning between her eagerly spread legs – my cock just swelled thicker and thicker.

Finally, I rolled over. Emma was on her side, facing the opposite way.

I put a hand on her ribcage, and I could feel her tension as she strained to remain still. Her breath was fast and she tried to quiet it.

I moved my hand down her ribs. She had a silky camisole on, and I worked my fingers beneath it and back up, under the shirt, nudging her arm away so that I could get my fingertips to her left breast. I found her nipple after my hand slipped over her silky skin, and when I did, the nub was already fat and stiff. I pinched it lightly between my fingers, and Emma stirred.

Such a liar, such a lying, cheating whore, I remember thinking. Pretending to wake up when she was already so wildly awake. I could feel her heart pounding through her chest, against my wrist. I wondered if she was thinking the same thing, if she could tell that whole time that she lay there that I was awake, burning with jealousy, accusing her in my mind of the filthy things she had done with Alec.

My cock twitched against her lower back. I moved my hand from her breast to her back, slipping my fingers beneath the little boy-short panties she was wearing and into the crack of her ass. I pulled them down as I did this: I wanted to fuck Emma now, and I wasn't going to take no for an answer.

Her skin was damp. I kept moving my hand further.

Emma did not roll over as she usually would have, to pat me on the cheek and tell me there were too many people getting up in the house for this. Instead, her body pushed against mine, strung taut like a bow, ready to spring.

I felt her thighs contract as my fingers dipped further, fanning to push her legs open a little. I brushed over her asshole, which was also wet. But now the wetness had changed from the squeakiness of shower water to the slimy moisture of her excitement.

Or was it something else? Had Emma let Alec pump her cheating cunt full of his cum? Had she spread her legs for him and let him fill her up?

I was about to pull my hand up and smell my fingers, checking for the scent of her indiscretions, when Emma made a sleepy moaning sound, and she rolled around to face me.

She didn't open her eyes or look at me, but she caught my hand in hers and pushed it to her pussy. "That feels good," she said sexily, using her forefinger to direct mine to her clit. She mewled. Her lips parted. "Don't stop," she whispered, as I started to pull my hand away.

What's a guy supposed to do? She lifted her leg and placed it on my thigh. Her skin was hot and smooth. The scent of her pussy wafted up to my nose, and I couldn't make out what was in it, if it was any different than just the ordinary, day-to-day differences. She smelled like a fragrant soap she had just used, and her tangy excitement. Maybe there was a foreign, acrid scent... but maybe not. There was little time to contemplate all of this, though: Emma pushed my fingers into her slick folds, then inside of her. She was hot, silky, and incredibly wet, and the vague promise of some of that wetness being Alec's cum, whether true or not, intoxicated me.

My cock was throbbing so intensely there was no way I was going to let the opportunity go: I curled my fingers toward the root of her clit and felt a satisfying shudder travel through her body. I did it again, pressing my thumb against her clit. It was hard, swollen with excitement, and I pinched it between the fingers I had embedded in her cunt.

She mewled, and I rolled over, lying on top of her, pulling hard at her panties until they stretched so far that they ripped. I felt the scratch of hardened, dried juices at some point in this struggle: the recognition of what that was, and all that it implied, rose up inside my mind only to fuel my energies at getting inside of her. All the while I was layering image after image of how those panties got wet the first time, and then crusted over while she slept on the dock under a blanket with Alec.

My weight sank into her soft flesh: the taut softness of her abdomen, the perky globes of her breasts and their marbled nipples, the squeezing heat of her thighs. I stroked her clit with my fingers as I pulled my hand from inside of her, sending another delicious ripple through her body. If she had spread her legs for Alec, had she come, over and over again, her body pulsing beneath his as it was now for me?

Her eyes were closed and she bit into my shoulder as I entered her. This was something new, something she didn't do.

Inside, she felt as she always did, but wildly excited. Maybe, I thought, as she squirmed beneath me, it was only the *idea* of having done something bad that excited her so much. Not that she had actually done it.

Or maybe – and this made my cock pulse, and her hips rise from the bed – she *had* done something terrible, and she was raw with guilt, or thinking of him.

I was lucky that whatever the reason, Emma was in fact wildly turned on, and she ground her hips against my pelvis and then squeezed, her pussy exploding with hot liquid around my cock, because this final thought – that she had been a very, very naughty wife – sent me tipping over the edge.

I came inside of her violently, slamming my cock deep inside of her.

What happened next? I lay down on the bed and wiped the sweat from my forehead. Emma pushed her hair from her face. She was breathless, her cheeks were flushed.

I remembered thinking later how strange it was – and how incriminatory – that nothing was said then. After all, people who are married as long as we are say *something* when, out of nowhere, they have really hot sex.

Don't they?

But Emma just smiled, and then sat up abruptly. “I'm going to go help Luz out in the kitchen,” she said.

Her back was to me: she was looking for something on the floor.

I found her panties, and started to lift them. She turned and snatched them from my hands, before I could investigate them further.

But what would they tell me? I think Emma's face told me more as she pulled them on quickly, then seemed to change her mind, pulled them off, bunched them up, and stuffed them in her suitcase.

My mind was on a little fantasy trip about those actions: that she had done that just to drip my cum into the panties, to cover up for the damning evidence from Alec, when she threw yet another twist into the story:

“Oh,” she groaned. “I'm so hungover. I should have gone to bed with you.” She was changing into cutoffs, pulling a tank top over her head. Her hands moved with shakiness, the kind of big, sloppy movements that a bad hangover imposes on someone getting dressed.

Or was it the shakiness of a liar? Was Emma, who I had always trusted to be loyal Emma, Emma of the wide smile and the clear, unfiltered view into her heart, Emma of only good intentions, Emma who would never even think of touching another man – was Emma actually lying by omission, letting me believe that she had slept all night by my side?

She pulled a shirt over her head and tossed her hair around with her fingers before sighing and opening a drawer, searching for a hair band. “You know I passed out on the deck? I was out there all night.”

I blinked.

“I know,” she said cheerfully, and leaned on the bed to kiss me on the cheek. “Crazy bad decisions.” And then, with a little smile: “But this morning was fun.”

Emma left the room, and I watched her retreat and close the door carefully, as though she might wake me. I was as awake as I would ever be, my heart pounding in my chest.

I scanned my memory – which is far from photographic, full of holes, a thing that Emma complains about constantly and which I believe is perfect though all evidence points to it being quite bad – for the scene I had taken in on the deck. A red blanket, Emma's hair... but was I sure, was I totally certain, that there had been another person there next to her?

And then, was I certain that it was Alec?

I strained to see better, I cursed myself for not paying more attention. I even considered asking her directly, which is what a mature man might have done.

But a question like that is an accusation.

And a question like that also did something that, deep down inside, I didn't really want to do: it would have laid the matter to rest.

Evidently, that wasn't what I really wanted.

CHAPTER 4

I didn't tell the full story, of course, to Thalia. I told her about the strip poker, the skinny-dipping, the huge hangover. I left out my antics, my sneaking down to watch Alec and Emma in the water together. Chris added his own footnotes to the story, affirming that he had been "screwing" in the little bay under the willow trees, and musing on the virtues of his previous girlfriend. Thalia seemed as bored by this information as anyone could be.

Thalia's big, bedroom eyes blinked slowly and with disappointment when I stopped talking.

"That's it," she said in a low voice, not asking, more like pronouncing it as though she were speaking of the status of the recently deceased. "This is the story."

She brought a cigarette to her lips and lit it. Then her brown eyes moved lazily from my wife to Chris to Alec, speaking volumes as they did. The corner of her mouth fluttered, as though she wanted to smile but could not.

She was still naked, stretched out on the towel. The story *did* seem fairly boring in that light; after all, Thalia did not seem to think nudity was too risqué.

I didn't like the look of knowing in her eyes, though. The way she was connecting the dots, from Emma to Alec, smiling as she figured out for herself what was missing from the story.

She stood up suddenly, though in the slow, sinewy way of hers, and took a drag from her cigarette before starting to walk up the stairs. "This," she said, "was a very boring story. I am going to bed."

Chris left immediately, because "bed" was obviously not code for "sleeping" between those two. Alec leaned back on the deck to finish a drink.

"Who's up for skinny-dipping?" he cracked, and he did it in such a way that it was obviously a joke. He was standing up even as he said it. Emma pressed her lips together and rested her chin on her knees, looking out over the lake.

She knew it was a joke, she was saying. Just not funny.

Alec slapped me on the shoulder and tossed back a final swig of his drink. "I'm going to bed, good buddy. See you in the early hours for some fishing?"

And he was gone.

I looked at Emma, who rolled her eyes. Then she pushed her hair from her face. "I'm glad you didn't drown," she said. She yawned. "I think I'm going to bed, too."

She stood up.

I didn't move. The world was spinning, I felt pretty sick, I'd dredged up all of these old memories, I didn't want to go fishing the next day... you name it.

I waved her away. "Ima stay out here and look at the stars for a while."

Emma frowned. "You're gonna pass out out here."

I had a tequila shot in my hand, and no idea how it had gotten there. I drank what was left of it. "Then we'll be even," I said.

Emma went to bed, but try as I might, I cannot remember how she got up there or if she said something else to me before she did.

I woke up because I was cold. For a moment I had no idea where I was, and a creak near my head made me sit straight up. I caught a glimpse of the lake, my heart slammed against the wall of my chest, and then everything went dark as something soft landed on my head.

I almost screamed, like a woman, but I stopped myself at the last moment when I felt that the item on my head was fuzzy and soft.

A blanket.

"Oops," came Thalia's voice.

I pulled the blanket down to my lap just in time to see her long legs, dangling from her jean shorts, pass by my face to the left. "I didn't mean to wake you up. You know you really should not sleep out here, it's going to get really cold. Like ten. I don't know what that is in your Fahrenheit system but it's too cold."

Thalia sat down with her back to me, her feet in the water, which must have been tremendously cold. She had a white hoodie on, and her long black hair cascaded from inside the folds. She lit a cigarette.

"Can't sleep?" I said lamely.

Thalia blew smoke in a straight, neat line. She turned back to me. Her face was pretty; she didn't look sleepy. She gave me a wry smile. "It's almost four o'clock," she said. "I'm done sleeping."

I pulled the blanket around my shoulders. The water beneath me had sent quite a chill through the deck and I was very cold. I didn't want to look like an ass in front of Thalia by shivering, though, so I kept it to a minimum.

I was trying hard to think of something to say, when Thalia blew more smoke in a stream. "Do you think your wife slept with Alec?" she asked me, cool as a cucumber and without any warning.

"I... what?"

She turned back again, spinning around on the deck and crossing her legs – she was not wearing any underwear, again.

"You heard me. You think she slept with Alec?"

I spluttered something, and Thalia smiled, bringing her cigarette to her lips. "Or maybe you just want her to?" she said, her eyes glittering.

My mouth snapped closed, because I was slowly figuring out that I wasn't going to say anything intelligent, and because I was stunned.

Thalia twisted her lips to send the smoke away from my face. It made them plump and tantalizing. Her eyes were on my mine, playful and knowing. "I can tell it turns you on."

I still didn't know what to say. Thalia seemed to expect this, and she grinned. She was single-handedly the most freakish thing I'd ever come across in my life.

For a while she didn't say anything.

Thalia smoked and rolled her eyes. "You know it's not very fair," she said. "I won the bet, and you haven't told me anything."

I objected by making a really scandalized face and shaking my head. "I told you the story."

Thalia shrugged. "Whatever. You and I know there is much more to that story than that."

I tried my best to look like I didn't know what she was talking about, and she rolled her eyes again. "Why would you not want to tell it, if all there was to it is, 'oh, we got so drunk, we swam naked, it was so crazy...'" Thalia ended her mocking with a derisive laugh. Her accent was much stronger, mistakes popping up in her speech. I wondered if she was drunk, or really excited.

I pondered this, and then I had a thought. “Well,” I said. “It was a silly bet anyway. I don't even remember why I made it.”

Thalia found this funny, and laughed and nodded, looking into the brightening sky over the lake. But she changed her expression and flicked her ashes with a shrug. “Fine,” she said. “You don't want to tell me, so fine.”

An ominous pause. A bird chirped.

“But I think we could maybe help each other out.”

She was standing up by the time her words made their way to my brain. Unzipping her hoodie, letting it fall next to her.

Getting ready to undress, I guessed, and jump in the ice-cold morning water.

I gave a moment of respect for her lean curves and her dark nipples, and how they would look dripping wet and hard as rocks as she floated away on her back on her swim, her shaved pussy dark pink between her legs. I gave another moment to thinking about what it would be like to sink into a lake-cold pussy.

Thalia started to pull on her shirt.

Maybe we could help each other out.

“Wait,” I said.

Thalia dropped her shirt, and swung her loose hair as she looked back at me. She was still poised to get naked and jump in the lake. She arched her eyebrows, indicating that she wasn't going to make it a cakewalk for me to ask what she meant by “help each other,” and she wasn't going to waste any more time with my half-truths.

“What did you mean by that?”

Thalia let the shirt drop and turned to face me, one hand on her hip, where the bone made a neat curve into her short shorts. Her shirt did not cover her navel, and her dark skin winked at me beneath the hem.

“Rick,” she purred. “I can only help you out if you are going to stop being a... a, what is the word for this? Stop being a *puto*, just tell me what happened, and I can get you what you want.”

I felt like we already both knew what I wanted, so I sighed. “And what about you?” I asked. “What do you get out of the deal?”

Thalia waved her finger at me and tisked. “Nuh-uh,” she said.

I felt a cold sensation in my stomach. I looked behind me, to double-check that no one was hiding in the bushes or coming down the steps. I

sighed again, and this gave me another jolt of cold, sinking arousal in the chest.

“Okay,” I said, whispering and moving my eyes side to side like I was telling a racist joke. This amused Thalia, whose mouth turned up in a devilish grin. She took a step toward me and rested her free hand on the hand already on her hip.

“I... well, you already know, okay. I think there's a thing between my wife and Alec.”

Thalia rolled her eyes. “Anyone can see that.”

This landed hard inside my chest, like a kick.

“Did they fuck?” Thalia asked me.

Jesus, she was blunt. I swallowed. “I don't... I don't know.”

Thalia narrowed her eyes and peered up at the house, as though she could see into the past by doing so. “Hmm,” she said.

Her big, brown, delicious eyes dropped down to me. “And do you want them to?”

I opened my mouth, and as a reflex, I started to say “Of course I don't!”

But Thalia's mocking look cut me off. She started to shake her head.

“Of cour-” I cut myself off. “I mean... I don't know. Maybe.”

Thalia's eyes burned through mine. She dropped to a crouch and bounced in it. She had no underwear on, that much was confirmed. “I think,” she said, and her voice was so sexy it sent a chill down my spine, as though she were fingering my balls. I almost had to look to make sure that she hadn't actually touched me. “That you are the kind of man who wants to watch your wife fuck another guy. And *I* think that your wife is the kind of woman who wants in secret to get fucked by a guy like Alec. And I don't think it would take much to make it happen.”

Breath traveled through me, I wouldn't have been able to say in or out. It was shaky, my stomach turning circles and my heart on fire.

Is that actually what was going on here? Thalia saying that she thought my wife wanted to be fucked by Alec had lit me on fire. Thalia dropped her eyes to my crotch and smiled.

“But what's in it for you?” I managed to say.

Thalia grinned. “So I'm right.”

I looked back at the house again.

Thalia stood up. "Let's just say that I could use someone... *distraying? Dis...* getting the attention of Alec. For a while."

She took off her shirt and wriggled out of her shorts at that point, and I stared at her, blinking slowly.

Her hair, silky and black, moved in a single wave as she looked back at me over her shoulder. "You want to join forces or what?"

It wasn't until after she smiled at me, let her hands drift sensually up her back, caressing her own skin, as she pulled her hair up to tie it quickly into a beautiful knot; until after her feet left the deck in spring that seemed surreal, as though she had not jumped at all, after she cut into the shallow water at just enough of an angle to glide gracefully into it without belly-flopping, that I realized what I had done.

Just moments before all of that, I had said:

"Uh...Uh... well, I... yeah, okay sure -"

And Thalia had winked.

And then she was gone.

She turned and waved at me from the water, and I thought maybe I would try to take it back, but by then she was far out, and she started swimming before I could act. She was gone for more than an hour.

It may seem strange that it took me a long time to sort out "the reason" that Thalia wanted Alec "distracted" by someone else. When I landed on the only real possibility, it seemed too surreal to be true. Thalia wanting to go after Luz? This was the sort of thing – like grown women having a pillow-fight in nothing but baby oil and skimpy lingerie – that didn't *actually happen* in real life.

Also, Luz didn't seem like the kind of girl that would haul off and have a lesbian experience. She seemed, as she always had, like a Mexican barbie-doll version of June Cleaver.

Or maybe this was Chris's idea, and Thalia was just into it because of him.

That made more sense to me as a probable explanation, if only because the idea of Thalia chasing after Luz for herself was just too... erotic to be true.

"Dude," a voice said behind me, after I had sat on the dock freezing and contemplating all of this for a long time. "Did you fall asleep out here?"

It was Chris.

"I... uh... yeah," I stammered.

"See Thalia?"

I pointed at the lake.

"Shit."

Chris didn't expound on this. He sighed. "Goin' fishin' with us?"

"Uh... yeah, I mean, I guess."

"What time did she leave?"

I looked up at Chris. He was more concerned than I had ever seen him before about where his girlfriend was. Half the time I wasn't even sure he remembered he *had* a girlfriend unless she was directly sucking his cock.

"I guess like, when the sun was coming up, I don't know how long ago -"

"Shit. Man, I really wanted her to come." He looked down at me. "She can spear a fucking fish, man."

He waited for this to have sufficient effect on me before taking a large step in the direction of the stairs.

"Wait a minute, you going to -"

Chris was already walking up the steps. "She'll be out there all day, man. At least an hour. She probably swam to the other side." He took a few more steps. "Bus is leaving in ten."

And then, from the top:

"Alec's saying get a move on, man. Sun's up."

The ladies were staying home. Emma lifted an arm at me and told me I should be dead, she wasn't getting out of bed for smelly fish. This was no surprise because she hated fishing. It was also a relief to everyone because Emma was notorious for trying to hook your eye.

I doubt Alec even asked Luz, who I had never seen outdoors anywhere except the dock, and she looked wildly uncomfortable there.

I'm a decent fly fisherman, but I had an off day and caught only one small trout. This was ultimately fine, because I didn't think any of us had licenses, but we were fishing at a spot where I had never seen another person in all my life.

I fell asleep while Chris and Alec kept fishing, well into the heat of the early morning, which was a waste of their time but not something I wanted to interfere with.

I fantasized, instead, about Thalia's plans. Fantasized and let myself be terrorized by them. Sometimes I thought about just letting them play out, however they did. Other times I resolved to put an end to them as soon as we walked through the door.

After all, I didn't need to get into any of this with my buddies. What would become of our trips, and our friendships? What would happen to my marriage if my wife strayed?

And yet... I couldn't get the idea out of my mind. Thalia's knowing grin as she said, with so little doubt in her voice, that my wife was the kind of woman who wanted to fuck a guy like Alec. The way she had seemed like I had told her the sky was blue when I said I thought there was something between them.

I flip-flopped all morning. Alec gave me a good ribbing for only catching the one fish. Chris had caught two, and he had thrown them back in with mine. "Thalia probably caught like fifty fish with her teeth, man," he explained.

"Man she is *hot*," Alec said. "But she seems a little... wild, if you know what I mean."

Chris laughed. "Oh, I know what you mean."

Alec shook his head. Then he looked at me. "Emma looks like she's been working out," he said.

Chris let out a low whistle. "Emma's a fucking hotty," he agreed. He was putting his gear away. "Better watch that shit around Thalia."

Alec caught this quicker than I did, and gave a whirl. "Don't tell me that girl's a dyke," he said.

Chris shook his head. "Not a dyke, you dumbass. But she likes to get it on with the laaaadies. And she doesn't mind if I watch."

Alec rubbed his head patronizingly. "You lucky fucker." He looked at me. "Isn't Chris a lucky fucker?"

"He is," I said amicably, just to end the conversation, which was making my head spin. Did this mean Thalia was for real with her offer... and that she would help me set up my wife and Alec?

And did I actually want that?

"Look at that," Alec said, after we closed the trunk and I dropped into the car. "Rick here had a hard-on just thinking about it."

I rubbed my eyes.

Chris laughed and started to tell a story about Thalia and a couple of sorority girls in Mexico on Spring Break, which sounded pretty far-fetched. When I tuned in. But mostly I was thinking of my own fantasy. And it didn't involve Thalia. Or sorority girls. Or Chris.

CHAPTER 5

When we got back to the lakehouse, there was a plume of gray smoke coming from the back of the house and the scent of cooking fish filled the air.

“Told you,” Chris said, referring, I guessed, to his claim that Thalia would have caught fifty fish and cooked them by the time we got home.

None of the women came out to greet us, but we could hear them in the back of the house, laughing. It sounded from there like they were well into another bottle of tequila. If they were, I had to give props to Thalia for convincing Emma to loosen up two days in a row. Usually, she had one big night during the whole trip and then felt guilty enough about it to stop drinking entirely. She stayed off the peer pressure radar (or more precisely, Alec's radar) by walking around with the same bottle of beer as though she were drinking from it.

We put our gear away in the shed and tossed the fish Alec had caught in the freezer. Alec looked slightly annoyed that whatever was going on in the backyard had stolen his manly-hunter thunder, or maybe he was just irritated that Luz hadn't appeared as she usually did to fawn all over him. He called the first shower.

“What'd I tell you?” Chris said, as we walked through the back to the steps. “Already cooking.”

The women were spread out on the deck on blankets, with several cans of beer and bottles and glasses scattered around them. Emma was in her trusted black bikini, with boy-short bottoms and a racerback, simple top that didn't expose much. It was still a cute, sexy suit, especially with her new toned muscle and leanness. She was stretched out on a blanket, looking relaxed and hot.

Luz was poking at a fire they'd made in the only flat place available, where it looked like they'd dug a hole into the ground for a pit and piled an inferno on top of it that had cooled down. Luz was wearing a spotless white bikini that perfectly showcased her figure: her breasts barely moved as she jabbed absent-mindedly at the fire (an act of manual labor I had never dreamed I'd see Luz engage in). Thalia was in a stringy, skimpy red bikini that looked like she had thrown it on as an afterthought. She and Luz were

speaking Spanish and laughing, very close, very flirtatiously with each other.

Well, I'd be damned... it looked like Thalia not only had a plan, she was efficient at getting what she wanted.

I looked over at Chris. He surveyed the scene as though it were just an ordinary day in his world, which, knowing Chris, it probably was.

"Thalia, how many fish did you catch?" Chris called out, winking at me.

"Oh, *mi amor*, I didn't count them," she said, in a throaty, sexy voice. But she seemed to be talking to (or for) Luz's amusement more than our information, and the two women giggled and made some kind of joke in Spanish.

Emma looked up at us, beaming earnestly. "Sooo many fish," she said excitedly. "*And she built this fire pit, and they're almost ready.*"

Thalia put a hand on her hip and turned her attention on us. "How many fishes did the boys catch?"

"One," I said.

"Two," Chris said at the same time, and Thalia was already laughing when he told her he'd thrown them all back.

Luz fist-bumped Thalia, which I took to be a sign that her plan was working, at least for her. But from the looks of it, Emma seemed more enthralled with Thalia than she had ever been with Alec.

Emma hopped up the stairs. "Gotta pee," she said breathlessly. "Oh, my God," she whispered to me. "Thalia is like, so cool. She stabbed all these fish with a *stick* that she whittled *herself*."

I was about to comment on this, when Emma added. "Where's Alec?"

Hope flared anew in my chest as my wife displayed some interest in Alec.

"Shower," I said, trying to sound like I was just telling her where Alec was, and not silently urging her to go get soapy with him.

Emma was already on her way into the house. I noticed as she passed that she was walking slightly unsteadily and smelled like hard alcohol.

Just a little, like she'd spilled a shot on herself. But still.

"Come here," Thalia said. "Come and have a beer and some food. Celebrate your big crop of fish."

We hopped down the stairs and joined them, and before long Alec was slowly walking down the stairs. He eyed the fire.

Thalia looked at him and a mocking smile teased the corners of her mouth. "I went fishing, too."

"I suppose you chopped all this firewood yourself, too," Alec said, recovering nicely.

Thalia drank a shot of tequila. "Don't be stupid, I'm not an *obrero*. We went to town in Emma's car," she finished looking at me and pointing with her shot glass. "You know that thing has no air *acconditioning*, so when we got to town we were all sweating, covered in sweat?"

She was smiling in her eyes as she looked at me.

"And so," she said, after letting her comments simmer there for a moment, letting each of us picture the three lovely women covered in a sheen of sweat in downtown Lake Walker, "we made a really great discovery, that there is a dance club just opened in that little town just outside of Walker. And we are going tonight."

She put her arm around Luz's shoulders.

Which was... intriguing.

"Dance club," I repeated.

Emma was coming down the steps. She laughed lightly. "She's just messing with you," Emma said, squeezing by me and picking up a half-finished beer next to her chair. She took a sip and explained no further, but the girls exchanged looks and giggled.

"No, no," Thalia said. "We were invited, and so we are going."

Emma rolled her eyes.

Luz waved Thalia away.

The guys all looked at each other.

"I'm up for dancing," Chris said, hopping onto his hands and pulling some kind of impossible break-dancing move. "Lake Walter laaaadies. Whoo!"

"It's not that kind of dance club," Emma said, becoming a little uptight but still smiling.

Thalia had a bottle to her lips now. "It is *exactly* that kind of dance club," she said sexily.

And they all shared a little laugh again.

Emma looked at me. "It's a strip club," she said. For her, the matter began and ended there. Case closed.

Alec clapped his hands together and whooped.

Chris said, “Yeah-ha,” from the edge of the dock before falling into the water. When he emerged, swimming, he said, “laaaadies.”

Emma looked from Alec to me, her lips slightly pursed. “We’re not *going*,” she said.

Alec looked down at her from where he was standing. “Why not?” he asked innocently.

Emma rolled her eyes.

Thalia had an arm around Luz’s shoulders, and a gleam in her eyes when I met them. She was smiling inside as she took a sip of her drink.

See? She seemed to be saying. *My plan is working perfectly.*

I decided, probably at that moment, that it was best to let Thalia put her plan into action, and just sit back and enjoy whatever ride we were going to go on. For one thing, it didn’t seem like Thalia was a stoppable force.

And for another, I wasn’t entirely convinced that my sweet wife would go along with some crazy idea.

And for another... well, I wasn’t entirely sure she *wouldn’t*.

Thalia’s plan (and you can hardly fault her for this) seemed to largely consist of making sure she got everyone good and drunk.

As she cooked and served up her fish, cooked in some Mexican style where it had been buried in tin foil with a strange mix of tropical fruits under the fire, she kept refilling every drink she could. As we ate lunch the story of their strip club discovery emerged: they had indeed arrived in town all covered in sweat. I pictured the three of them walking down the otherwise uninteresting streets of Harris, a mid-sized small town with a ton of touristy grocery and fishing supply stores on the outskirts of Lake Walker, for people like us. Some guys had, inevitably, stopped them, and asked them to point them in the direction of The Star. It emerged that they had thought the girls worked there, and then they had told them that Friday nights were great fun with lots of ladies there as well as men, because it was pretty much the only game in town.

It sounded pretty raunchy, which I knew was appealing to Chris and Alec (and, in some ways, me). It sure seemed to appeal to Thalia, but I was starting to see that anything might.

Luz was not giving off any signals one way or the other.

But the big surprise was that Emma seemed... not enthusiastic, but a little interested in it. She wasn't staying away from the topic like it was a barracuda, as I would have guessed she'd do.

Thalia didn't bring it up while we ate, or all through the afternoon into the early evening. She just kept giving everyone drinks, and the occasional side-show of her naked body as she took a swim.

But she worked her magic in very subtle ways, asking me to help her with something by the fire, or go get water, while she nudged Alec and my wife together gently.

Luz, Thalia did indeed seem to be keeping for herself, working on her at the same time, offering to loan her clothes if they went out that night. Touching her arm, laughing gently a little too close to her ear. Luz did not seem to be recoiling from any of this, that was for sure.

The light was getting low in the sky, around 8:30, when Thalia stood up and made her move. "Oh, my God," she declared. "Luz here has never been to a strip club before."

Emma was sitting next to Alec, and they were sharing their usual friendly-not-friendly banter, but she broke away from it to look up at Thalia with something like fear in her eyes.

Thalia looked at her. "Don't tell me *you* haven't either."

Emma laughed nervously and wiped her cheek with the back of her hand. "I haven't... well it isn't... I mean, why would I have been....?"

Thalia made a big theatrical deal out of looking shocked, but I was onto her game by then: it was all just an act.

And it was working.

"Guys," she said, addressing me and Alec by moving her gaze between the two of us. She made a face. "You can't be serious. How could these two lovely ladies never have had any fun in a strip club before?"

I let my eyes wander to a place where I could take in Alec, Emma, and Thalia as everyone reacted to this. Emma was far too social-justicey to have set foot in a strip club, or admit to it if she ever had. I was also wondering how many women actually went to strip clubs on a regular basis.

Emma made a few movements with her mouth, like she intended to say something, and it wasn't the thing she would usually have said. She finally was unable to say anything, so just shook her head.

And then she looked rather helplessly around... to Alec.

"Listen to her!" Chris called from the lake. "They're so much fun!"

“Aren't you even just the least bit curious?” Thalia cooed at Emma.

Surprisingly, she didn't seem too interested in convincing Luz, and I would find out later why that was. Luz was looking at her fingernails. She shrugged. “It could be interesting,” she said.

Alec's eyes went wide. It was clearly something he hadn't expected his wife to say.

And yet... he didn't linger too long on Luz. He faced *my* wife, absorbed in what Emma might have to say.

Chris gave her a slow clap from the lake.

Everyone turned to Emma, who I could see was blushing a little, though the sun she'd taken in for the day hid it.

She seemed wholly surprised to have everyone turn on her like this.

“Emmmmmmma,” Alec said, putting his hand on her neck and rubbing it gently. The two of them, with the help of a few more drinks, had lost their political-animosity-act and started being friendlier and friendlier. “Come on Emma. We can't go if you don't go with us.”

Emma sniffed.

Thalia took a drink and smiled, devilishly, in Emma's direction, but her eyes flicked up to meet mine when she said, almost too low to be audible, “It won't be any *fun* without you, Emma.”

Emma pinched her nose. “Oh, why...?” she muttered. “How would we even get there-?”

“Uber!” Chris shouted quickly, leaping from the lake to fish his cell phone out of his shorts. “I got a guy, he took me into town the last time when I fucked my shin up.”

I looked around quickly to see if I was the only person who had absolutely no recollection of this event, and it seemed I was not. But no one really seemed to care about Chris's mystery accident when the prospect of taking three women to a strip club was within reach.

“Yeah,” Chris said, reading from his phone. “Andreas Papa...loppa, I can't say his name but he can take us. Want me to call him?”

Chris really loved strip clubs.

“Well... I mean, not yet,” Emma said quickly. “We have to change... and stuff... first, right?”

“Is that a 'yes?'” Alec asked, his fingers still gently grasping her neck. He gave her a playful shake. Emma looked at her feet and smiled.

“It is. Oh God. Oh dear sweet Jesus. Emma Orr has just agreed to go to a strip club with us!” Alec stood up, with his hands in the air, declaring victory.

Finally, Emma looked up at me. Her expression was one of helplessness. There was no backing out now.

I could have acted like it wasn't okay. I could have admonished her a little bit, just like I could have confronted her about the year before, and the skinny-dipping, and the sleeping outside with Alec.

But I didn't. Instead, I said, to her, over the cheering:

“Sounds like fun.”

Thalia was triumphantly knocking back some beer, because evidently, this fell under the umbrella of her plan.

Who was I to mess things up?

Thalia, as chance would have it, had a sequined black top she could lend to Emma, whose first attempt at thwarting the plans was explaining that she had nothing to wear.

“Just wear it with some cutoff shorts,” Thalia said. “And it will be fine.”

“No hay codigo de vestuario?” Luz said in a low whisper.

“Es un club de *striptease*,” Thalia shot back. She flitted her eyes. “She wants to know if there's a dress code,” she translated, to everyone's amusement.

Luz muttered something in Spanish about “*porqueria*” and disappeared into her bedroom. I knew she would come out glammed up, because that's how Luz rolled, but I wondered briefly what Thalia's plan was here. Luz did not seem to happy about going anywhere where people didn't wear proper evening attire.

Emma was holding the skimpy sequined top. “I dunno...” she said.

“No?” Thalia asked, not seeming like she cared too much. “Go ask Luz, I bet she has something you can wear. *I'll* wear this,” she added, dangling the sequined top, which somehow seemed to get smaller and smaller in her hands. She trotted away to the room she was sharing with Chris at the back of the house.

Emma looked around at us, became suddenly uncomfortable, and pointed to the hallway before walking away toward where Luz had disappeared.

Chris laughed. “What the fuck is *going on*?” he asked rhetorically. “I’m not going to jinx it,” I said.

I looked at Alec. I wasn’t 100% certain what he was thinking, but if someone had to ask me, I was 100% certain he was giving my wife more thought than his own.

The ladies were back there for a while, and it started to sound fairly giggly and conspiratorial, which I don’t mind saying made me fairly nervous. At last, they all came clattering out of the back rooms together.

Emma was wearing a clingy black dress, which was a little loose and must have been borrowed from Luz. On Emma, it was quite short, just grazing her mid-thigh, and as it shifted around her, it rode up and gave glimpses of her inner thighs far higher than anything she would normally wear. It had a deep cut between her breasts, and the fabric was a gauzy, sometimes-transparent mirage of a dress. It was incredibly sexy, a tiny bit slutty, and a perfect ensemble for whatever incredibly sexy, slightly slutty promises lay ahead.

Luz looked as she always did, too good to be real. Her bleached hair was piled up on her head, her perfect figure flawlessly filled every nook and cranny of a tight red dress that looked extremely expensive for reasons I could never explain, and she had darker red heels on that looked as though they had just been taken from a box. Why the woman had those things at a lakehouse is anybody’s guess, but then Luz was the kind of woman you’d expect to put on makeup while her plane went down, just to look her best for the coroner.

Thalia had on her small, short cutoffs, and the scrap of fabric she had been calling a top. I was glad my wife hadn’t put it on, because 80% of it was transparent, with only a few well-placed sequin flowers covering her nipples, and these looked like they would shift any moment to give a glimpse of the whole thing. It was trashy, but Thalia, with her long hair and her defiant features, somehow made it look like a classy kind of trashy.

They were all drunk as skunks and smiling. “Okay,” Thalia said. “We are ready for a good time.”

Emma bit her lip, indicating that she still wasn’t sure if this was going to be a “good time.”

Thalia passed out drinks casually, and as she gave one to Emma she said something in a low voice. Whatever she said had the miracle effect of making Emma drink it.

I had personally counted Emma's drinks at four shots and two beers. And this did not include anything she'd had before the boys got home. For Emma, this was quite a bit, and she was definitely getting loosened up.

A lot.

We waited for Chris's Uber, and when he arrived, we realized our problem.

"We can't all fit," Emma said plainly.

The driver, a man who was as stereotypically Greek as anyone I had ever seen in my life or the movies, waved us into the car. "You can fit, you can fit, just a short drive."

Emma was shaking her head slowly and saying, "nahhh." So maybe she wasn't that drunk.

Andreas Papalapawhatever got out of the car. Gold chains swung under a silky dress shirt, buttons loose to mid-chest. He had on dress pants and a lot of cologne. "Come on," he said. "You wait, maybe an hour for another car, or I come back. Twice the price. I get you another car to come home, maybe my son. Where I come from, we put a horse in a car this size one time, I'm not even joking with you. I saw it with my own two eyes. Just put the ladies on the lap."

As he was saying all of this, he was pushing people into the car and waving his hands at us in the sort of foreign way that is both reassuring and terrifying.

Thalia and Luz had already piled into the front seat, speaking Spanish, and Thalia had convinced Luz to sit on *her* lap.

Emma had begun to cross her arms. She was a safety marshal through and through, and while fire hazards were her favorite go-to, she had a thing about seatbelts that took a close second.

Chris was in the middle of the back seat already.

I touched Emma's elbow.

Alec slipped a hand around her shoulders and pulled her close to him. "Come on, Emma. It's a short drive, no traffic."

And then he leaned close to her. I very distinctly heard him say, "I'll hold you tight."

He pulled her by the elbow toward the opposite side of the car.

And she went.

My heart kicked at my chest as I stepped, with jell-o knees, toward the open back door. The driver was rubbing his hands together saying,

“Here we go. Nice car kebab.”

Thalia shot me a look beneath the headrest of the front seat; a wicked grin, her eye flashing. Then she ran her tongue along her top lip and turned her attention back to her own target, Luz.

It was very, very hot, and for a moment I was caught up in a little daydream about Luz and Thalia, who weren't my primary interest, but, let's face it, I wouldn't have minded watching them together in the least.

“I can't believe I'm doing this,” I heard Emma say, which turned my attention to my wife.

She was seated on Alec's lap, and somehow in getting into the car, her skirt had ridden up her thighs, exposing her leg almost to the hip. She had crossed a leg almost over Chris's lap, and Chris was not too shy to put his hands on her calf and situate her better on his leg.

Chris looked at me, grinning. “Just making sure your wife is comfortable,” he said.

It was all done in the hazy, drunken way that we used to do things when we were younger, but the dangerous undercurrent beneath it made my balls throb.

Emma squirmed on Alec's lap. I was sure he was enjoying that, feeling her tight, firm ass rolling over his cock. I wondered if he had a hard-on, if Emma could feel it against her ass, maybe throbbing against her pussy. I wondered, too, what she thought of it: if she was just being polite, not saying anything, not looking like she'd noticed? Or if she was twisting her hips discretely, just to roll her bottom over him, make his cock pulse in pleasure, and measure his girth in her mind?

Or was she remembering him?

My blood ran cold, and it was delicious, as I let myself sink into that fantasy. After all, they didn't seem unfamiliar with each other. Emma wasn't uncomfortable, sitting there on his lap, feeling his dick get hard under her thighs (and it *had* to be), with Alec's hands on her waist, “holding her tight.”

The driver was a lively guy, who kept the conversation fun, and funny, and off the topic of sex. Though Thalia was not hesitating to whisper things to Luz, and I felt sure that I could see Alec breathing secret nothings into Emma's neck as we drove. When I looked over at them, it all seemed pretty tame: Emma was holding onto the handle, looking out the window, an expression of drunkenness and no more on her face.

And Alec was doing the same.

But it *seemed* to me that something was boiling between them.

Thalia met my eyes again, reminding me gently, silently: I *wanted* something to boil between them.

After all, why had I let my wife sit on Alec's lap in the first place?

CHAPTER 6

The drive was about twenty minutes, and the driver promised to get a second car for when we wanted to go home, no problem. He was amused that we had convinced the ladies to go to a strip club, and even more amused when Chris told him it was their idea.

Emma came over to me, a little unsteady in some high heels she had borrowed from Luz, which were about half a size too small for her. She caught herself as she stumbled by resting her hand on my shoulder.

"I can't believe you're doing this," I said, into her ear. "I can't believe you rode in the car like that."

Emma pushed on my shoulder and lifted a foot to adjust her shoe. "Oh God," she said. "Me either."

I realized that Emma was thinking only of the fact that she had ridden without a seatbelt. I wanted to tip the scales a little, so I added:

"Did you have a nice time on Alec's lap?"

I was instantaneously a little sorry I'd said that, because Emma's reaction was almost certainly going to be scandalized, and then she would feel bad, and then she would stop doing anything that could be interpreted as flirting with Alec for the rest of the night.

I'd blown it, I was thinking. It hit me hard, like a belly-flop.

Emma put her foot down and turned to look at me.

She surprised me by smiling coyly. "Why?" she purred. "Are you jealous?"

My cock throbbed. Emma looked slightly scared right after she said it, but watching my reaction, a look of relief spread over her face. She also seemed...

A little more confident.

She smiled and put her arms over my shoulders. "I see," she said.

I put a hand to her waist, hoping to pull her to me and ask her what she "saw," but the whole group was moving toward the lights that hung above The Star.

The hottest, the newest, the best, and the only stripclub in the town of Lake Walker.

I'm not going to lie and say that the inside of The Star was spectacular, but it did exceed my expectations by quite a bit. It had a new feel about it, so there hadn't been time for the paint to fade or chip, or the mirrors to get cracked, or the smells of sin to work their way into the walls.

But – and this is just about where it was – it wasn't the classiest place I'd ever seen.

It did, however, have a decent group of girls dancing, and a decent crowd, with a few women mingled in for good measure.

“Must be the only place for anyone to go,” Emma murmured into my ear. She was looking around in wonderment. “There are a lot of girls here. In the audience, I mean.”

She was holding onto me by the elbow, which felt nice. Alec had strolled into a large, c-shaped booth around a table that connected to the stage via a catwalk, and already attracted a waitress.

I maneuvered Emma in front of me to pass through some other people to the booth. The guys passing us, I noted, took a good long look at my wife, up and down her body. I reached for the hem of her skirt with my fingers, hoping to pull it down a little after our ride in the car.

Instead, my fingers went under the skirt, into her bare skin. I felt something wet and sticky on her thighs.

Emma squirmed and turned back to look at me, tugging on the skirt. “Hey!” she said.

But she was smiling.

“Just fixing your dress,” I said, finding the hem and tugging on it.

“Right,” she said. She slowed as she approached the booth, and turned her face slightly toward me. I could see she had become a little hesitant. She leaned closer to me. “Okay, so, what do you do?”

“What?” I yelled toward her as some loud music started.

“What do you do? Here?” she asked me, yelling back.

The truth was, I'd been to two strip clubs in my whole life, and both times, I hadn't been into it much. The girls were pretty trashy, and I felt uncomfortable most of the time.

“Just... you know, have some drinks and watch,” I said confidently.

I leaned closer to her, taking a chance at the new game we seemed to be playing: “Maybe Alec will have some tips for you.”

I was surprised again when Emma did not roll her eyes, as I would have expected. Instead, she gave me a strange smile over her shoulder.

And then she said – or at least, I'm pretty sure she said - “Maybe he will.”

As luck would have it, Emma slid into the booth, and there was nowhere else for her to go but over, closer to Alec. Thalia had taken Luz by the hand and pushed Alec inward so the two girls could sit together on the other end of the booth.

Whatever Thalia was doing or saying, she seemed to have worked her magic on Luz. Luz was good and drunk, a lot more sensual and messy as a result (a strand of hair had escaped her flawless updo and her makeup, though still flawless, looked like real makeup that might smear with the right stimulation, which gave Luz a filthy appeal I had never before seen in her).

Importantly, Luz also seemed to have forgotten she was married, so Alec was free to turn his attention on my wife.

He took another leisurely walk up and down her torso, his eyes lingering on her breasts, which pushed firmly against the gauzy material and threatened (or promised) to burst out of the thin, almost transparent confines of the bodice. It was a nice sight, and watching Alec enjoy it as much as he did made it even more pleasing.

A new song was starting, and three new dancers were strutting out onto the stage. The stage was pretty cool, connected to some of the tables at the center of the booths by catwalks, giving a lot more people an opportunity to look up close at the dancers. There was a pole in the center of our table (a bar-like ring around the stage, so maybe table wasn't the best word for it).

A willowy, ethereal blond in pink strutted in our direction. She was captivating: even I had my attention distracted for a moment by her rounded thighs, her high, bubbly butt, and her dancer's abdomen of flat muscle beneath two pillowy, perfectly spherical, and probably fake boobs, all with nothing more than cotton-candy-colored wisps of fabric hiding her from us.

She began a very routine dance at our table. I looked over at Emma, who seemed a little uncomfortable, though most likely because she didn't know what to do.

The stripper smiled at her, which made her blush.

My eyes drifted to Alec, whose arm was draped over the back of the booth and made it easy for him to drop his fingers to Emma's bare shoulder and pull her toward him.

Emma let her eyes fall to the table. She listened to whatever Alec said as his fingers lightly stroked her shoulder, and then settled back against the couch, but much closer to Alec than before. Hesitatingly, she lifted her eyes and watched the stripper, who was beginning to do some really extraordinary things on the pole.

The dancer spun around and around on the pole, her legs spread in a half-split. Her thighs were long, thin, and well-toned, and the sight was quite something. She did a few turns, got back on her feet and spun around several times with her hands on the pole, hanging her head back and letting her breasts fall down, bouncing, her abdomen stretched out lean as she bent over backwards.

Then she slid down, the pole to her back, her legs spreading open as she dropped to the ground and then popped back up. She did it several times, until she finally sat down, spread her legs in a wide split, and gave us all a view of the very small patch of pink that covered her bare, waxed slit. She removed her skimpy top in a long sensual tease as she sat there, and Chris, who had sat down next to me, clapped in appreciation as her tits were freed from the fabric and bounced wonderfully loose (and actually, looking very real) with her large, caramel aureole and long amber nipples jiggling as she shook herself.

I looked at Alec, who was looking not at this spectacle, but at Emma. He was making no effort to hide the fact that he was watching her face as she watched the stripper, and getting off on it. Behind his face, in the unfocused blur of background images, I could see that Luz and Thalia were hitting it off, watching the stripper together.

I wanted to lean over and ask Emma what she thought about it all, but more than that, I wanted Alec to continue to guide her, ever so gently, to the dark side. So I waited.

Before long, the stripper was up and dancing again, leaning over and playing with the thin strips of fabric that held her panties to her hips.

She was good; this was not a full-nudity state, and it wasn't legal for her to show us everything. But she gave us (plausibly deniable) glimpses by sliding her fingers under the side of her panties and pulling outward on them just enough to let her pink slit peek out from behind the fabric before the panties snapped back into place.

When I looked over at Emma, she had a stone-cold serious face on. Alec was right at her ear, turned slightly toward the back of the booth.

But that wasn't the big deal.

The big deal was the way Alec's shoulder rolled slightly, while his hand traveled up Emma's thigh, right between her legs.

I looked down quickly to see his hand moving beneath her black skirt, which only barely made it to his wrist. I could see his muscles flexing beneath his skin as he moved his fingers, right up against Emma's panties, touching her right between the legs where she was hottest and craved it most.

Emma stared blankly ahead for a moment, and I was certain the whole thing would come crashing down any second. Alec was saying something in her ear, keeping her transfixed. Or maybe it was the stripper.

Suddenly, Emma looked at me, and her facial expression changed from spaced-out to guilty, like she had just been caught with her hand in the cookie jar.

It was now or never. As Alec's hand moved beneath the skirt, playing with my wife's pussy, I leaned over to her scared face, and slid my fingers into her hair to move her lips closer to mine. Her heartbeat was visible in her throat, pulsing wildly, her eyes wide and wet with fear.

I let this moment linger for a bit, because I realized that Emma had probably been talked into this by Thalia, was drunk, and things had rolled along faster than we ever had a chance to actually talk about it. There was something darkly beautiful, and hot, about holding her face to look at mine, while Alec continued to stroke her under her dress, and she was tense as a board waiting for my reaction.

I kissed her on the mouth, and she was so stunned her lips didn't move at all: her mouth was slightly open, in disbelief. She tasted like a sweet alcohol, and lip gloss clung to my lips. I dove into her wet mouth, exploring it with my tongue, claiming it rather aggressively.

When I finished, I bit gently into her lip, and let my eyes drop to her skirt. I put my mouth close to her ear, traced my tongue around the edge of her earlobe, and whispered:

"It's okay. This is what I want. Just be a little slut."

Emma exhaled next to my face, a little puff of relief or tension, a small moan at the end of it. Or maybe Alec had just reached a point in his exploration of her pussy that she found particularly pleasant.

Either way, when I leaned back, she was flushed and still had a disbelieving stare on her face. I saw Chris in the corner of my eye. He was

smiling, taking drinks off the tray from the waitress, and saying something very loudly about how it was going to be a good night.

I slid Emma's drink (or a drink, which I believed belonged to Emma), closer to her.

Her mouth opened slightly again. Her eyes were getting glassy. Alec met my eyes over her shoulder. He was entertained, I think, watching me watch him finger my wife.

I moved my hand up her thigh, pushing the dress with it. Then I wrapped my fingers on the top of her panties, and pulled them down to mid-thigh. Emma looked at me again, and I gave her a deliberate stare before nodding at her and leaning close to say: "It's okay. Seriously. I want you to do it. It's hot."

Alec had followed my lead, and was pushing the other side of her dress up to tug on her panties as well.

Emma started to freak out a little, turning her head quickly from me to Alec and back, her eyes darting around the room, looking at Chris, at the public place. "I don't -" she started to say.

Alec was the one who leaned in to her and growled in her ear. I didn't hear what he said, only saw how Emma's pupils were sucked into dots by her iris for a moment, and then released to turn dark and alert.

The panties, meanwhile, had slid to her knees with our joint effort, and Alec's fingers were working their way back up, back to the center of her thighs.

Our dancer was still at it, clad in only her pink panties, and probably a little confused as to why no one at the table, except maybe occasionally Chris, was really paying her any attention. I looked at her, but I knew I wasn't hiding the fact that I couldn't see anything she was doing because my mind was so fully occupied by the sights in my peripheral vision: the outline of Chris's hand as he worked under the skirt, pulling it up, and up, until Emma's bare thighs were fully visible at the lip of the table.

I could see his thumb slip between her folds, and I felt her shudder as his fingers plunged into her pussy and his thumb pushed on her clit. Emma made a sound that I could only hear because I was pressed against her and the sound traveled through my skin. A moan, maybe a gasp.

Her thighs were tight against mine, and they grew stiff the more Alec played with her. The scent of her pussy started to waft up from beneath the

table. I looked down in stolen glances to see Alec's fingers plunging in and out of her pussy.

Her body grew stiffer and stiffer as he went. She was looking blankly in front of her, at nothing in particular, her mouth open slightly. She began to move back and forth a little with the thrusts of Alec's fingers.

I took her hand, which she had clenched on the seat of the booth, and guided it to my rock-hard cock, to let her know it was more than okay. She flitted a look over at me, her face strange, her lips quivering, her eyes still dark and vacant.

Then her whole body shuddered, and I felt her orgasm ripple through her. I pushed her hand against my cock and rubbed it, almost bursting spontaneously with the arousal of seeing her face as she came, Alec's fingers still pummeling her, in a strip club and right there in public.

She squeezed her thighs together and leaned forward toward the table. Alec was grinning at me over her head. He kept finger-fucking her, and she started to squirm, trying to get away from him. But Alec was having none of it, he pushed her back to lie against the back of the booth, and mingled his fingers in her hair to pull her back on the headrest, looking up, but trapped there as he pulled her hair down.

"Oh my God," I heard Emma say.

Alec leaned over her open mouth and ran his tongue along her lips. I looked down at his hand, struggling to finger her as she pressed her thighs together more firmly. My cock pulsed against her hand, and Emma dropped her eyes to strain to look at me.

"Oh!" she said, loudly, but only Alec and I could hear her.

Alec finger-fucked her relentlessly, holding her by the hair and immobile against the booth, talking into her ear until she relented and let her legs fall apart. I tugged her leg open a little, holding her spread as Alec brought her to another orgasm.

This time, she shuddered violently, and I felt her wetness all over Alec's hand against the back of mine as he slid from inside of her. Her thighs were trembling, her lips shaking.

I had forgotten, pretty much, where we were, and I looked around briefly. Luz and Thalia were pretty much making out. Thalia had Luz's legs over her lap and she was playing with her hair: they looked like lesbian lovers, and weren't paying any attention to us.

Chris was watching everything, but mostly Thalia and Luz. He seemed pretty content with the show he was getting, so I turned my attention back to Alec, just in time to see him plunge his cum-covered fingers into my wife's mouth.

He put three of them in and whispered in her ear, giving her instructions no doubt. Emma closed her lips around his fingers and sucked her cum from them, then opened for him as he pulled on her mouth and said something into her ear that made her eyes go wide.

He released her hair, finally, and she sat up.

Alec turned to his wife and Luz, and there was a conversation among them as Emma turned to me.

Her lip gloss had come off where Alec's hand had rubbed her mouth, the plain color of her lips beneath the glossy shine a symbol of her bad behavior that was exquisitely sexy.

I kissed her, enjoying the tangy taste of her pussy on her lips, enjoying more replaying the image of her sucking that cum from Alec's fingers.

The girls were letting Alec get out, and he was leaving toward the restrooms with his back to us.

Emma looked at me for a moment.

Then she leaned closer to me.

"He wants me to follow him," she said, loudly, so that I could hear it.

Her tone made it almost sound like a question. I answered by leaning into her, kissing her, absorbing the liquid of her cunt on my tongue again. I slipped my hand between her thighs, and felt the wetness that coated both of them. When I rubbed against her clit, she shuddered and squeezed her thighs.

I gave her a nod, and she gave me a moment to change my mind. Her eyebrows went up for a second as she chewed her lip.

"Go," I said.

And so she did.

Chris gave me a look of appreciation and tipped his drink in a toast after Emma left. He watched the strippers for a while, but pretty soon we were both watching Thalia and Luz. A new girl in black, who had the vague air of a dominatrix, had captured Thalia's attention.

She beckoned the stripper over and got her to lean down and talk to her while she very sensually put dollars into her scant clothing.

But, more fascinatingly, she got Luz talking to the stripper and gingerly placing dollars in her underwear as well.

The stripper seemed to like Luz a lot, because she was talking to her and sort of forgot that she was a stripper for about five minutes. This was no problem for me and Chris, because we had a nice view of her round bottom and the floss-like strip that ran the length of her asscrack. It had become caught in the lips of her cunt, and was rubbing slightly in the length of her slit.

The time eked by, as slowly and as painfully as you can imagine it passing with a pretty, dark-haired stripper flirting with two women at your table. I finished my drink and ordered another from a cute blond waitress who looked just one day old enough to work at that place and overflowing breasts and an enormous, appealing bottom.

But I wasn't thinking about her, or the drink, and I didn't remember her bringing it back.

My stomach was cold, the taste of Emma's juices on my lips, the memory of Alec's fingers in her pussy clouding my vision.

What were they doing, right now? And where were they?

What had I given Emma permission to do? Everything? Anything? Nothing?

Was Alec the type to bend her over in the bathroom and fuck her right there? Was Emma the kind of girl who would let him do that?

I couldn't even believe what Emma had already done. Or how she'd been convinced to do it.

I caught Thalia's eye as I was sitting there, half-elated and half-miserable. She winked at me.

I leaned toward her. Luz was staring at the new dance routine on the main stage while sucking down another sweet drink.

Thalia was grinning.

"How did you convince Emma to go ahead with it?" I shout-whispered to her.

Thalia made a face and shook her head, pointing to one ear.

"How'd you get Emma to do it?"

A strobe light flashed and some new, louder music started. Some girls with exotic bird tails exited onto the stage in a cloud of fake smoke, and

Thalia's attention was momentarily sucked away by them. She gave a fluttery clap and squealed as she watched them.

I looked over at Chris, who shrugged mischievously at me.

Thalia leaned back my way just as I gave up ever asking her the question.

"It didn't take much," she said loudly, her eyes still on the strippers.

I didn't say anything, but another wave of cool, uncomfortable jealousy poured over me, moving like molasses over my skin. What the hell did she mean it didn't take much? To get Emma to fuck Alec, and act like a slut at a stripclub?

I was so caught up in these dark thoughts that I didn't feel Thalia's fingers sliding over my thigh until she reached my cock. She tapped my erect member, slid a finger up and down the length of my shaft, and smiled when I turned to look at her.

She gave me a look that said: "Don't act like you aren't happy about it," and ran her tongue on the edge of her teeth with a devious grin. Her fingertips were making a circle on the crown of my cock.

"What do you think she's doing right now?" Thalia asked me.

But she left that to my imagination, because Luz was pulling on her arm and Thalia had her own plans to get back to.

The minutes went by in a blur. I know, from thinking about it so often after it all happened, that they were only gone about ten minutes. It felt like hours, though, before I saw the waves of Emma's brown hair, caught in a bright light, making their way through the now-crowded club.

I assessed her appearance in glimpses. Her hair, one strand of it wet and caught on her neck. The back of it raised with slight static, as though maybe her head had been against a wall.

Another flash, another glimpse: her mouth, all the lipstick gone. Her expression a mixture of stunned and guilty.

My stomach twisted as I thought of what I would say to her. I looked over at Chris, who had found the waitress very attentive to his needs and was caught up in conversation with her with a hand stroking her thigh.

I looked back at where I had last seen Emma, and she was gone.

Now I saw only Alec, smirking as he walked, looking quite satisfied with himself as he strolled through the crowd with ease (people get out of Alec's way), to come to our table.

Luz and Thalia stood up, and Alec slid in, but the two women did not sit back down, disappearing instead into the crowd. It took me a moment to realize that the entire atmosphere of the club had changed; the strippers were taking a break, there was loud music and a lot more people, and many of them were dancing on a floor tucked into a corner of the place I hadn't noticed before.

I couldn't figure out what my feelings were toward Alec when he sat down next to me. It wasn't animosity, though I did burn with a particular kind of jealousy. I tried to read in his face whether he had fucked my wife, or something else had transpired between them.

Or maybe nothing at all, I thought both with hope and plunge of disappointment.

I turned away from Alec's smug grin and looked to see where my wife had gone. I saw her hair by the bar, where a lot of people had flocked to take advantage of the break in stripping I guessed.

"This place is actually really great," Alec said, leaning toward me to make sure I heard him over the music. "Who knew?"

The back of my neck grew hot. What an asshole, trying to act like there was nothing going on here at all, even though he'd probably just fucked my wife, and he had definitely finger-fucked her, right under my nose.

He looked at me for a minute, clearly enjoying my pain. Then, finally, laughing, he leaned toward me again. "That wife of yours has quite a mouth on her," he said.

I had a hard time understanding the feeling that surged through me: a mixture of rage and hot, beautiful arousal that punched me right in the gut. My cock was painfully hard, and it throbbed again, swelling inside my pants, pressing against the hem.

"I'm gonna go see what the gals are up to," he said cheerfully. He looked at Chris. "Hey man, that Thalia chick, is she trying to fuck my wife?"

Chris was deep into the waitress, but managed to shrug and answer: "Probably, man."

And then I was suddenly alone.

The DJ began to announce that the next dancers were coming on in five minutes, a drink special, a contest of some kind. I was feeling sick, like I might have to throw up under the table.

I looked over my shoulder again for Emma, and couldn't find her. I could see Alec's retreating form, and beyond him, the platinum blond of Luz's cascading hair, falling out of her updo.

I pulled my phone out of my pocket and sent Emma a text message, even though I knew there was almost zero chance that Emma had even remembered her phone, let alone would hear it and answer it.

[Me]: *Where are you?*

I stared at the screen and then tucked it into my pocket again. I looked around. I felt lost; the urge to throw up was receding, my cock was still hard, I didn't know what to do.

A long time passed, the girls never came back, Chris wandered away with the waitress. I wondered whether to give up our seat: a lot of people started asking me if they could have the booth.

My cheeks started to burn as I checked my phone again and again, looked into the crowd for any of the group, and shook my head apologetically at several more guys wanting the booth. A girl sat down on one end anyway, and her boyfriend gave me a look that indicated I was best off leaving her alone.

And then I felt the vibration of the phone against my thigh.

It was a message from Alec, a picture. I stared at my phone. For a moment I didn't understand what I was looking at, not at all. The shapes shifted on the screen as my brain tried to process what I was seeing.

And then it began to take form, the reality of it; it all fell right into place.

I was looking at Alec's fingers on the back of Emma's head, her brown waves between the dark blue of his pants. The implication clear: my wife was servicing his cock with her mouth.

But where?

I looked around again, finding no one. I didn't have anyone else's cell number except for Chris. I sent him a message: *Where the hell is everyone?*

I abandoned the booth. Panic – a very particular, strange kind – was rising up inside of me. I walked to the bar, unsure of what to do, my eyes seeking anyone I had come with.

My phone buzzed again.

[Emma]: *in the car. I thought you were following with that and Lucifer?*

It took me a moment to figure out that Thalia and Luz had been auto-corrected out of existence. I was starting to make sense of it all when someone grabbed my shoulders from behind. “Man,” Chris shouted at me. “You are fucking slow and hard to find. Come on.” He jerked his thumb in the direction of the exit. “We’re outta here.”

I slowly rotated to look at him, and he was grinning, jerking his head in the direction of the exit. “The ladies are waiting,” he explained.

I followed him, my eyes squinting, my head swimming. Just as I stepped into the night, my phone vibrated against my thigh.

Another message from Alec:

[Alec]: *your wife is going to suck my cock all the way home*

Chris was pushing me into the car, and I almost dropped my phone. I found myself in the passenger seat of an elegant sedan, with Andreas driving and staring at the rearview mirror. I looked behind me by turning my head gingerly in their direction.

Luz and Thalia were already in the back, and their pink tongues darting at each other in the soft bed of their locked lips. Thalia’s hand was moving up the length of Luz’s curvy, red-encased body, and they both seemed oblivious to me.

Chris opened a door and dropped into the back seat, his pleasure evident from his smile. “Andreas, my good man,” he managed to say, just before closing the door. “Get us home fast.”

Andreas grinned over at me, and I turned back to face front, my eyes wide with disbelief.

As hot as Thalia and Luz were, making out, the only thing on my mind was this sentence:

Your wife’s going to suck my cock all the way home

Behind me, Luz and Thalia giggled, and I could hear the low murmur of Chris getting in on the action. Andreas’ driving was sketchier with each

passing minute, but he did all right for a man who was only looking at the rearview mirror the entire drive.

I glanced backward from time to time, to see Thalia's tongue running along Luz's neck, while Chris slid his hand over her knee, traveling upward. In another glimpse, I saw Thalia sliding down into the wheel-well, twisting around, turning to face Luz.

But my attention was sucked back to my phone, and the picture sent to me from Alec.

It was the kind of dirty, amateurish porn picture that you stumble onto all the time on the internet: a woman licking the crown of a cock, her mouth open and wide for the eventual ropes of sticky cum that would spring from it.

But *this* woman was my wife.

And that cock was Alec's.

I stared as the image burned into my mind and my guts felt like they would fall right out of me.

Another buzz. The drop-down notification floated down, and the words burned over the image:

[Alec]: *she said she'll swallow my load.*

And as I stared at the screen, trying to catch my breath, another:

[Alec]: *does she do that for you?*

Emma didn't do that for me, I thought with burning jealousy.

Emma would never do that. Not for Alec. She wasn't that kind of girl.

For a second, relief came over me. This was all just a big cock-up – the pictures were fake and Emma was in the back of the car, maybe letting Alec kiss her or some other benign thing. But she wouldn't just jump in the car and start sucking his dick, let alone swallowing.

Emma just wasn't that big of a slut.

Was she?

The drive, like the wait at the stripclub, seemed to take forever. Behind me, Luz and Thalia were starting to really get it on, and the driver was starting to make me really nervous with how much time he was looking in the mirror.

We narrowly avoided hitting a guardrail.

"Guys," I said, clinging to the "Oh Shit" handle. "You need to stop that."

Thalia laughed. She sat up in her seat and wiped her lips with her finger. Luz mewled and complained in Spanish.

Chris hit the headrest of my seat. "Thanks, fucker."

I looked at my phone. The giggling behind me started up again pretty quickly, and the girls and Chris were back to whatever they had been doing in about two seconds. My screen was blank. I could see a car in front of us; it was the car Andreas had used to pick us up from the lake house.

So it was almost a guarantee that Emma was in that car.

With Alec.

Giving him head all the way home.

My phone vibrated again, and the image on the screen sent a knife of cold through me.

I clutched my stomach.

The picture was of Emma's mouth, her unmistakable wide smile stretched into a wide opening.

And there it was: a milky-white glob of cum, nestled in the pink of her throat.

I stared, paralyzed for a moment by the sensation that gripped me. The waves of jealousy that so deliciously tickled my cock seemed to freeze at the crest, locking me into a feeling of such intensity I was half-sure my eyes were going to water up.

I looked behind me when I heard a sound from the back seat, thinking that Chris would be staring over my shoulder, looking at the picture of my wife's mouth filled with another man's cum, and laughing. But Chris had turned himself to lean against the door and watch the two women now, which was understandable because they were making out heavily, their lips and tongues glistening and hungry.

I turned back to my phone, because while Thalia and Luz making out was hot, it held next to no interest for me at that moment.

Andreas gave me a strange look, and shook his head. Then he gazed into the rearview mirror and almost drove us off the road again.

We were coming closer to the lake house, to where we would all have to get out of the car. And then I would have to say something to my wife, and Alec.

What would that be? It weighed heavily on my mind, but the intense arousal of the picture kept drawing my mind away to the image on my screen. I pulled it up and stared at it.

Which is when Andreas really did drive us off the road.

It wasn't a bad accident. We hit a fence post and got thrown forward lightly, then sank onto the right side of the car. It was tipped slightly by the angle of a shallow ditch.

The girls thought it was hilarious. Chris said, "Jesus, man."

Andreas took a quick look around, saw that no one was dying, and got out to bitch about his car.

I had to climb out awkwardly through the driver's side, because my door was stuck against the other side of the ditch.

I don't know what happened with the car, or Andreas, or the ladies at that point, because I just started walking toward the lake house. I don't know if they called after me, or even noticed I was gone. Later, they said nothing about it.

It was about ten minutes, walking at a steady, zombie-like pace. Once or twice I thought about running, but there was something inside of me that wanted to give them more time. Maybe I was afraid to be there, maybe I was afraid to find what I would find. After all this time fantasizing about it, maybe I was afraid that the reality wouldn't be what I had hoped for, that I would want to take it all back and wouldn't be able to.

Andreas's son passed me on his way back. He looked at me skeptically and then slowed, rolling down his window.

"In a ditch, back there," I said, waving behind me. "Go help them out."

The kid furrowed his brow for only a moment, murmured "thanks man," and drove away.

I kept walking.

And then there was Emma. Emma acting like this, it was not how I had imagined things. Emma throwing herself into this, doing things like swallowing cum and letting someone take a picture of it? What was going on with her? Did I not know my own wife? Was she some whore and I had just never tapped into it, never realized it or been brave enough to do that?

I had a lot of time to think about it as I walked. The lake house seemed to move further away than I had remembered it. More fields and

patches of forest popped up, more bends in the road than I had ever remembered.

Finally, I saw it: lights on, quiet on the outside.

I paused, and for the first time noticed that the evening had cooled. My breath was a vapor, and a chill traveled up my arm. I looked at my watch: it had somehow gotten late, it was almost two.

I trudged up to the house, took a deep breath, and opened the door.

CHAPTER 7

Alec and my wife were on the couch in the living room, Emma seated on Alec's lap, her arm around his shoulders. She had yet another drink in her hand, and her shoes were off. The lower half of her dress was pushed up to just below her hips, and she had no panties on, I could see from there.

Her hair was messy, her lipstick worn off, her mascara a little smeared next to one eye.

"Ricky," Alec said, smiling at me. "We thought you would never get here."

I shut the door, lacking any idea of what else to do. I wasn't sure what to do at all, how to act, what to say. My stomach was churning with a wild mix of emotions: rage, jealousy, arousal, elation, fear. All of them came together as a cold snake thrashing inside of me.

Emma was smiling at me, though I felt sure I saw a flicker of concern cross her face. Alec turned his attention back to her quickly.

He said something, then, that I had to process for several moments as I stared at the scene in front of me. "Let's get this started, then," is what I thought, later, he had said.

Emma was smiling still, and they kissed. It was a dirty, wet kiss, and I wondered if he could taste the salty brine of his own cum in her mouth. Another knife of pain shot through me as his hand slipped between her legs. I distinctly heard the sticky crackle of his fingers exploring her wet pussy.

Emma's legs fell open a little, and I had an unfettered view of her cunt with Alec's fingers in it. My cock, which had been a little deflated by the walk and the cold, was now back to its previous swollen state.

Alec adjusted my wife with two hands, placing her on his lap like he was a chair. He then pulled her dress up and over her arms, and Emma's spectacular body was freed. Her tits bounced as he pushed her up to standing and unbuckled his pants, which I noticed were still wet with saliva or cum from their antics in the car.

He twisted his pants down so they were at his knees, and pulled Emma down onto his lap. His hands came around to cup her breasts, his fingers stroking, and then pinching, her nipples.

Emma leaned back against his chest – I was sure he pulled her to him, and he began to speak in her ear.

Emma, evidently at his direction, lifted her eyes and looked at me. I stared at the scene, unable to comprehend it, as Alec's big cock appeared in front of her pussy, wrapped by her pussy lips like a hot dog in a bun. Emma spread her legs open wide so that the whole sordid sight was easily viewable. She gyrated her hips so that her cunt slid up and down his shaft, the length of his member rubbing on her clit.

“That's it,” I heard Alec say. He looked at me. “I always knew your wife was a little slut. I knew it.”

Emma's mouth was open and she was off in her own world, rubbing her pussy against the column of meat in front of it, approaching an orgasm. I could see it in her flushed face.

Alec drew his hand up to her throat and massaged it gently, then squeezed her cheeks a little as he said, to no one in particular. “Emma here is really good at sucking cock, too.”

Emma was too busy making herself come, and come she did, after a few sweaty bounces against Alec's cock. He held her against his chest as she bucked and her legs trembled and shook. She tried to close them, but he spoke to her in her ear, telling her to keep them spread.

“Now,” he said, as Emma panted in his arms. “We give Rick here a real show.”

He let her lean forward, and with his free hand, he guided his cock toward her hole. I saw Emma shudder as the crown of his dick rubbed on her distended clit.

I was still standing in the foyer, staring. My cock was dripping precum.

Emma sank onto Alec's cock, and gasped as she did.

“Spread your legs,” Alec said in her ear. “Let him see it.”

Emma obeyed, and I got a nice eyeful of Alec's fat cock embedded in her pussy, stretching it wide and thin.

Alec drove into her, lifting his hips and pulling her shoulder to sink his cock in deep in fast, hard thrusts that made Emma gasp.

For a moment, they seemed to be concerned with putting on a show for me. Alec spoke to Emma. She met my eyes, and moaned, and complained that her pussy was sore but it felt so good. Much of this seemed to be prompted by Alec.

But then, he seemed to be unable to get what he wanted, and he pushed Emma onto the couch, to the side, on her face. Moving quickly, hungrily, driven by his own desires, he lifted her knees to the couch and got her on all fours.

Emma let him; she helped herself into that position, and then she lifted her head and gasped as he slammed into her pussy from behind.

Alec began to pummel Emma in hard, sloppy thrusts that filled the room with their sloshy smacks. He hit her like a machine gun, as Emma mewled and gripped the arm of the couch, taking his cock as hard as he gave it to her with a mildly vacant expression.

Alec's neck started to look strained, and his face was screwed up in concentration. "I'm gonna fill your wife up with a nice, hot load of cum," he told me. "Fuck, baby," he said, to Emma, "your pussy feels so fucking good."

A few more thrusts, and then he dove in hard, slamming into her ass. He groaned, and gripped her hips, and dumped his cum inside of her. He gave three final thrusts, randomly, spilling the last squirts of seed into my wife's pussy.

My mouth was slack, I was raging to fuck Emma, any way I could.

But Emma wasn't quite done. Alec had worked her up without satisfying her, and she was pushing back against his cock, trying to get some more.

Alec gripped her ass with one hand, his fingers digging into her flesh. "Agh," he said. "You have to wait a minute, baby." He backed out of her, and his cock flopped sloppily to his thigh as he leaned back, thighs to calves.

He was breathing with exertion, staring at Emma's ass, probably admiring his own handiwork. He lifted his fingers to her pussy and played with it, making Emma purr and grip the arm of the couch.

I couldn't take any more. My cock felt like it was going to explode. Whether it was crazy or not, I was moving toward my wife, unzipping my pants, pulling my cock out, while another man played with her pussy.

Emma was so distracted by what Alec was doing that it took a moment for her to look up and see me. I rubbed my dick on her mouth, smearing my pre-cum over her used lips.

She opened her mouth and took the crown inside of it. She was playful, licking the rounded dome of my dick inside her closed lips. It was

something she had never done before, and I wondered if it was yet another thing that came from Alec's instruction.

Alec.

Emma mewled, her voice vibrating on my cock, and I lifted my eyes to Alec at that moment. He was staring at her ass, playing with her pussy, but also... I watched as his fingers moved up, made a circle around what had to be Emma's anus, and then he sank one finger into her taut hole.

Emma let my cock fall out of her mouth and tried to turn her head. "Oh," she said, as though she were confused.

"Just relax," Alec said calmly, sinking his finger in deeper. He looked up at me and grinned.

I put my hand down, slipping my fingers into Emma's hair. I pushed her toward my cock, holding it out for her with one hand. She took me into her mouth, all the way, and I heard the low mewl of her voice against my shaft as I went in deeper, and Alec did as well.

Alec began to finger-fuck her ass, and I stared at his hand as it moved back and forth. I didn't have a great view, but I knew what he was doing, and I marveled that my wife was letting him. While she sucked on my cock.

It didn't take long for me to boil over. I gripped Emma's hair, and tapped on her lightly to let her know I was close to coming. I pulled back gently on her hair when she didn't respond, and she lifted her eyes to look at me, my cock still partially in her mouth, as my cum spurted into her mouth.

Her eyes seemed glazed over, and her eyelids heavy. For a moment I didn't understand, but as her body rocked slowly, I started to get it: Alec was finger-fucking her and had her very close to coming.

I looked at what he was doing: he had his fingers spread out, his palm turned to the side, and he was plunging in and out of her pussy as well now, I could tell by the sound.

Emma let out a shrill moan and dropped her head to the arm of the sofa as she came. "Oh my God!" she yelled. "Oh!"

She tried to squirm away after a few moments of squealing, but Alec gripped her with his free hand and continued to fuck her with his other hand. I moved slowly in his direction, wanting to get a better view, my orgasm having depleted me to the point of shakiness.

Alec gave Emma a swat on her ass – a bright red mark materialized, almost in the shape of his hand. I sank into an armchair facing the door and the foyer, so I had a direct view of what Alec was doing with my wife. His

pointer finger was moving in and out of her ass, and he had three fingers bunched together to fuck her pussy. Emma's feet twisted in pleased discomfort: she was squirming as though she wanted to get away, but she wasn't trying too hard.

Alec gave her another swat, and I was stunned to see that Emma's pussy welled up with even more excitement. I stared at the red mark: was this really my wife? Letting herself be spanked and finger-fucked in the ass?

Alec then surprised me, and Emma too, by pulling his hand out of her pussy, and leaning back on his heels again.

Emma mewled, and tossed her hair as she looked back over her shoulder. Her face was flushed, she was ready to go again. She looked to Alec in confusion.

Alec was stroking his cock, looking at Emma, and I could see from his profile that he was smiling wickedly. "What's the matter?" he said to Emma. "Do you want some more cock?"

Emma chewed on her lip. She wasn't a big dirty-talker. She opened her mouth a little, but nothing came out.

"Show me," Alec said. He slapped her ass again, and Emma yelped, but she seemed to enjoy it. I watched a sparkling drop of juice well up from inside of her and slide down her thigh.

"Oh, you like that, don't you?" Alec said. He gave her another swat, and Emma yelped again. Alec rubbed the red mark he had left, working the burn of it into her skin. Emma chewed on her lips some more, and watched him.

"Show me how much you want me to fuck you again, baby," Alec said.

My own cock, which had never really gone soft, was already back in action again. But when Emma slid her hand up to her ass, and let Alec guide her fingers to her hole, it sprang up and slapped against my thigh coming back down. I watched as she sank her own fingers into her ass, and started to fuck herself in the ass. She was looking back at Alec, but after a bit, she moved her eyes in my direction.

Then back to Alec. He looked at her for a while, called her a good little slut, and edged forward on his knees toward her. "Keep it up," he commanded. "Keep fucking that little ass like that."

And he plunged into her pussy again, leaning back on his calves a little to direct his cock upward, against the membrane of her ass, against her fingers as they plunged in and out.

He fucked her like this for a bit, and Emma started to pull her finger from her ass, but he reached for her wrist and held it firm to her butt. "Keep it in there," he said. "That's it."

His cock plunged into her pussy at this strange angle, making Emma howl, for at least another five minutes. I stared, frozen in place.

The room was silent except for his breathing, the occasional mewl from Emma, and the sloshing of her very wet pussy.

He pulled out and pushed Emma down to the couch when he came, slapping her arm away from her asshole and spurting his cum right at her reddened ring. Some of it sank into the gape, the rest fell in ropes across her lower back, between her thighs, into the sloshy mess of her pussy.

Alec collapsed on the couch, his cock throbbing in the air. It was engorged and red from all the wild fucking he had just done, and glistened with my wife's juices.

Emma remained as she was, panting, her ass covered in Alec's cum.

I was hard, wondering what to do next, when Alec's phone rang and he fished it from his pocket. "Oh," he said casually, and said, "Where are you guys?" into the phone.

I suddenly remembered everyone else, and the reality of the evening threatened to crash in on me. Uncomfortable, I stood up, zipping up my pants over my uncomfortable erection. I found Emma's dress on the floor and handed it to her.

She had turned to sit on the couch, and looked up at me in confusion. I shrugged, unable to explain myself.

"Sweet," Alec said to the phone, and held it in front of him to end the call. He seemed unconcerned that he was sitting on the couch, his cock covered in my wife's juices. He leaned over to Emma, who was sorting the dress out to put it on, and grabbed her hair to pull her to him. He kissed her wetly on the mouth.

"I guess those guys are at the driver's house," he said casually. "If you want to come."

I could see that Emma didn't, really. Though who knew, anymore? I obviously didn't know my wife at all.

I waited for her to say something, but she put the dress over her head and folded her knees up to her chin. She was starting to look less like the confident slut she had just been, and more like a lost waif.

Alec stood up, buckled his pants, and clapped me on the shoulder. "That," he declared, "was a great time."

He strolled toward the kitchen.

Emma was looking at the window.

"Do you want to go?" I said softly.

Emma looked at me. "I don't know," she said unconvincingly. "If you do, I guess... yeah, if you do."

We heard a beer bottle being opened.

Alec strode out to the living room, jingling his keys.

"You're not driving?" Emma said suddenly.

"Barely drunk," Alec said. "This is my first one today. Should we head?"

Emma stood up, looking down at herself. She was a mess.

It was tempting, for sure, to see what would happen with the rest of the evening. But I could see it was time to wrap it up. In fact, I could think of nothing better.

"I'm beat," I said. "Emma looks..." I waved in her direction.

"Yeah," Emma said softly. Then she hugged herself, because it was quite cold. "I think I'm going to bed."

"Suit yourselves," Alec said cheerfully.

And then he was gone.

Emma and I stood in the living room, looking at the door, for a long time. I knew we needed to say something to each other, but I had no idea how to start that conversation.

Emma put her hands to her face. "I can't believe I just..." she said.

She looked at me, worried.

"Emma," I said, pulling her close to me by the elbow. "It was hot. I just... I just..."

I just what? Something had me unsettled, and I couldn't put my finger on it.

"How long has this been going on?" I said finally.

Emma looked at me, her face confused and then suddenly angry.

"What do you mean by that?" she snapped.

“I mean, you and Alec. You can't tell me this is the first time you ever hooked up with him?”

Emma's mouth fell open. “What?!”

I folded my arms. I hadn't meant for this to turn into a fight, and now I wanted to retreat, but I was too drunk to know how.

“I only did this,” Emma said firmly, “because of what you said to Thalia.”

If there had been a soundtrack for my life, that's where the record would have scratched.

“Huh?” I said.

“Thalia. You *told* her you wanted to watch me with another man. And Alec's always had a thing for me, he's always been crossing the line, and, and... I admit it, I thought about it. But not like, not like some *affair* or something!”

“Wait, wait, wait,” I said. “Thalia told you this? When?”

I was trying hard to remember if I had ever specifically said this to Thalia. I was sure I hadn't.

It was true, but I hadn't *said* it.

Emma looked shocked. “Don't...” she said, her voice much weaker. “Oh, God, don't tell me that this is not what you wanted?”

She sat down, shaking her head. “I knew I shouldn't have listened to her, but she was like, so convincing. She said it would be better if I didn't say anything, that you were too... you know, shy to talk about it. Oh God. What did I do?”

She looked miserable.

I sat down next to her. “No, Emma, no...listen. It *is*... I mean, it was my fantasy. It was, I just, I didn't *say* that. This was hot. I promise. I just didn't understand why you... you were so different, it wasn't like you...” I drifted off.

It was all starting to make sense now.

“So... you never slept with Alec that last time we were here?” I said, veering off course with the first thing that came into my mind.

“What?” Emma said. I could see from her expression that she was genuinely shocked by the idea. “No. God.” She paused. She put her hand up to her face. “No way.”

“But you were asleep out there with him,” I countered.

Emma looked confused for a long time, thinking, before she laughed. She shook her head. "That was Chris's stupid girlfriend, you idiot. And she was so passed out we had to drag her there. So no. Not what happened."

We sat in silence again. I was relieved, but the events of the night still lingered between us.

Emma played with her hands. "I only did this because I really thought... I really, Thalia was so, convincing... I thought it was your fantasy."

I was silent.

"Everything added up," Emma said softly. She looked at me, and I saw that her eyes were wet. "You seemed so okay with it, at the club, here..." her voice broke.

"Oh, Emma," I said, "No, no, don't..." I pulled her toward me, and heard her snuffle away some tears as she leaned on my shoulder. "It was my fantasy," I said quietly. "It's okay. It was hot. I just... I didn't expect it."

Emma was quiet.

"I guess it was my fantasy, too," she admitted.

"What, Alec?"

Emma shrugged. "Just... yeah, Alec, I guess. And when Thalia told me that you wanted it, I guess I just jumped on it, and believed her because... I wanted to do it."

She was quiet for a minute. "I only did it because I thought you wanted it. You know?"

I pushed her away from me so I could see her face. Her eyes searched mine. I kissed her, and the kiss was more passionate than any we'd had in such a long time. Like a first kiss, like getting to know a new person I wasn't sure of, a different woman.

I realized in that moment, though I couldn't really parse it for myself, why I had wanted this: it was a chance to get back to the unknowable, the new, the different.

We looked at each other for a long, intense moment, and then I started to slide my hand up her thigh, over the sticky wetness of her excitement, and Alec's cum. I knew I needed to reclaim her, make her mine again.

I pulled her legs up to the couch to get her beneath me. She looked worried for a moment, her eyes flitting back toward the door. "What about...?" she said.

I shook my head, and covered her mouth with mine. “They're busy,” I think I said. I stood up, taking my clothes off while she wriggled out of the flimsy dress. She pulled me to her, and I sank inside of her used and soaked pussy.

She was sore, I could tell, as she shifted beneath me. I kissed her gently, and played with her nipple with my left hand, making a slow circle with my fingers before lowering my head to suck on her. I could feel her body straining against the pleasure and the soreness as I moved inside of her.

From there, it happened more quickly than I would have expected after so many things had happened that night: we rocked together, slowly at first, feeling our way around the new reality of our relationship, of making love, of coming back together.

I came inside of her, filling her with my seed, and her pussy clenched around me as she ground her hips up against me, before she seemed to burst into hot liquid around my cock. Her eyes met mine, wide and open, almost stunned, and I knew that she was back to being mine again.

Later, in the dark, a thought hit me and woke me, as though I had been hit in the face by a cold wave. I remembered the lake, Emma and Alec floating so close to each other. What had happened between them?

My heart beat rapidly and my body grew hot, and I turned to Emma. I think I thought for a moment that I would wake her up, demand the answer to my question.

But when I looked at her sleeping soundly, next to me, having come back to *me*, I lay my head back down and decided against it. I had lost my chance to ask her about it; the moment had come and gone. If I really thought about it, it didn't make any difference what the answer was: Emma had lived out a fantasy and come back to me.

We had trust now, and I would just have to be satisfied with that.

We woke in the morning and made love again, and the house was still empty when I came out of the bedroom to make coffee. Emma took a long shower, and appeared in the kitchen looking fresh and squeaky clean, her cheeks pink and her hair wet, smelling of lavender.

She looked around the room, at the remnants of our wild “party,” and shook her head.

“I never thought I'd be... doing this at this age,” she said shyly.

Then she squinted. “Where are those guys?” she asked.

I shook my head. “With Thalia, who knows?” I remarked, and Emma smiled shyly.

“Do you want to get out of here?” I asked. “We can leave a note.”

Emma slipped off the stool, nodding, and went back to start packing.

“What was Thalia's deal with all this?” she asked, when we were putting our luggage into the car. “I mean... why?”

I smiled. “I'll tell you on the way. It's something I think you'll want to be out of here for, because it's pretty wild.”

Emma raised her eyebrows, and her mouth turned up in her quirkiest smile. I loved that smile.

And I understood now, for sure, that it was all for me.

“I think this might be our last lake house trip,” I said, surveying the property. Or at least, I thought it. There was something conclusive about this event, and I knew it was time to end.

Emma dropped, unsentimental, into the passenger seat, and we drove away. She faced me in the car, waiting patiently with her smile, to hear all about Chris's wildest girlfriend yet.

She was scandalized.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Working On Her Game

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn't long before the couple discover that Scarlett's new instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

*Don't forget to check out [Game For More](#), the sequel to *Working On Her Game**

[A Taste For Teasing](#)

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

[Ela's Performance](#)

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies... And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

[The Houseguest](#)

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-

sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just

the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He

can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken. But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor - the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Hotwife Suspense By Arnica Butler

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be “Clothing Optional.” They’re even more surprised to find out that “Clothing Optional” is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

*Explore **darker** themes by Arnica Butler:*

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he

doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.